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PAPER 1 OF 11

Digital Westphalia: AI Sovereignty as the New Frontier of Geopolitical Competition

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DOI: 10.59461/JGSSO.2026.01.0001

Digital Westphalia: AI Sovereignty as the New Frontier of Geopolitical Competition in 2026

ABSTRACT

This paper introduces the concept of 'Digital Westphalia' as a theoretical framework for understanding the emerging tripartite competition between the United States, China, and the European Union over artificial intelligence sovereignty. Drawing on classical sovereignty theory and adapting it for the digital age, the study proposes an original 'AI Sovereignty Index' comprising six dimensions: compute infrastructure, foundation model autonomy, data governance, talent pipeline retention, regulatory independence, and military AI integration. Through comparative analysis of national AI strategies, investment patterns, and regulatory architectures across 2020-2026, this research demonstrates that AI governance has become the defining axis of great power competition, superseding traditional domains of territorial and economic sovereignty. The paper argues that the international system is entering a period of 'Digital Westphalianism' characterized by the assertion of sovereign control over AI ecosystems, the fragmentation of the global digital commons, and the emergence of competing normative orders for artificial intelligence governance. The findings reveal significant asymmetries in AI sovereignty capabilities that carry profound implications for international security, alliance structures, and the future of strategic stability.

Keywords: AI Sovereignty, Digital Geopolitics, Great Power Competition, AI Governance, Digital Westphalia, Strategic Technology, Compute Infrastructure, Foundation Models

1. Introduction

The international order is being fundamentally reshaped by the competition for artificial intelligence supremacy. As governments increasingly treat AI assets—foundation models, training data, and computing infrastructure—as national security priorities and critical infrastructure, the traditional Westphalian conception of sovereignty is being extended into the digital domain. This paper introduces the concept of 'Digital Westphalia' to describe the emerging international order in which states assert sovereign control over their AI ecosystems with the same vigor historically reserved for territorial boundaries and economic systems.

The year 2026 represents a critical inflection point in this transformation. The United States has channeled unprecedented government investment into domestic AI infrastructure through executive orders and CHIPS Act Phase II allocations. China's 15th Five-Year Plan (2026–2030) has designated technology self-reliance as a core strategic priority. The European Union has proposed the AI Continent Action Plan and the Cloud and AI Development Act, seeking to establish a distinctive 'third way' between American market-driven and Chinese state-directed approaches.

This paper makes three original contributions to the literature. First, it proposes a comprehensive theoretical framework—Digital Westphalia—that synthesizes sovereignty theory with the unique characteristics of AI as a strategic technology. Second, it develops a novel 'AI Sovereignty Index' comprising six measurable dimensions that enable systematic cross-national comparison. Third, it provides empirical analysis of how the tripartite competition between the US, China, and the EU is restructuring the international system, with particular attention to the implications for middle powers, alliance structures, and strategic stability.

2. Theoretical Framework: From Westphalia to Digital Westphalia

The Peace of Westphalia (1648) established the foundational principle of state sovereignty—that each state possesses supreme authority within its territorial boundaries. This paper argues that we are witnessing a parallel moment of systemic transformation in which sovereignty is being redefined to encompass the digital domain, particularly artificial intelligence.

2.1 The Sovereignty-Technology Nexus

The relationship between sovereignty and technology is not new. The Industrial Revolution created new dimensions of national power that reshaped the balance of power in the 19th century. Nuclear technology in the 20th century introduced the concept of 'technological sovereignty' in the realm of strategic deterrence. AI represents the third major inflection point in this trajectory, distinguished by several unique characteristics that amplify its sovereign significance.

Unlike nuclear technology, which required massive state investment and remained largely within government control, AI development exists at the intersection of public and private power. The concentration of frontier AI capabilities among a handful of corporations—predominantly American—creates a novel form of power asymmetry that challenges traditional state-centric conceptions of sovereignty. Governments must now negotiate not only with other states but with corporate entities that possess capabilities rivaling or exceeding those of many nation-states.

2.2 Defining AI Sovereignty

This paper defines AI sovereignty as a state's capacity to exercise effective control over the development, deployment, governance, and strategic application of artificial intelligence within its jurisdiction, while maintaining meaningful autonomy in these domains relative to external actors. This definition encompasses six measurable dimensions, which together constitute the AI Sovereignty Index proposed in this study.

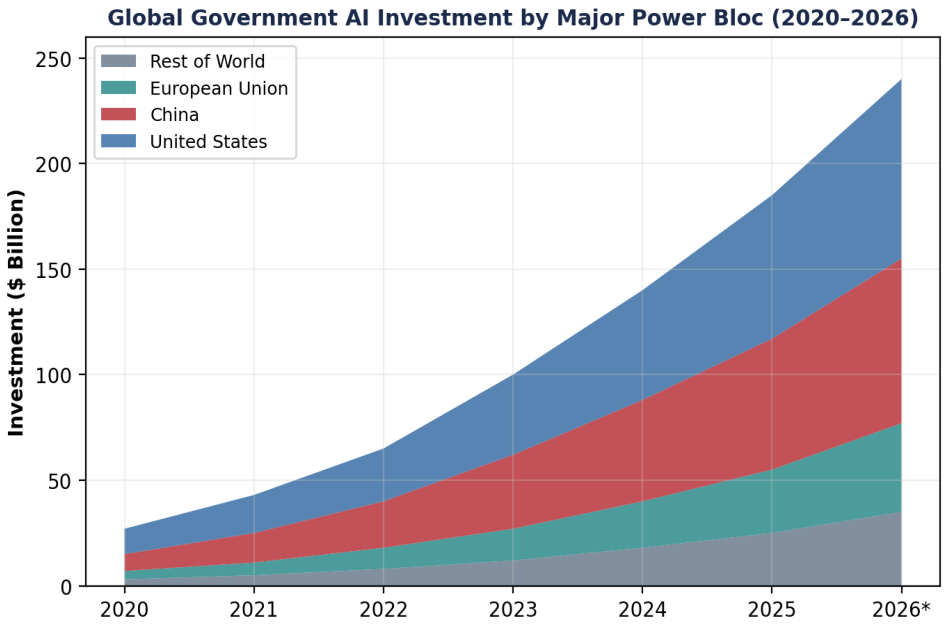

Figure 1: AI Sovereignty Index — Comparative Assessment of Major Powers (2026)

3. The AI Sovereignty Index: A Novel Analytical Framework

The AI Sovereignty Index (AISI) proposed in this paper represents an original contribution to the measurement of state capacity in the digital age. Drawing on methodologies from the OECD Government AI Readiness Index, the Stanford AI Index, and the Global Cybersecurity Index, the AISI integrates six dimensions into a comprehensive assessment framework.

3.1 Compute Infrastructure (Weight: 20%)

Compute infrastructure encompasses the hardware ecosystem required for AI development, including advanced semiconductor fabrication, GPU/TPU manufacturing, and data center capacity. The United States maintains a commanding lead through NVIDIA's dominance in AI accelerators and the concentration of hyperscale data centers on American soil. China has made substantial progress through Huawei's Ascend chips and massive state-funded data center construction, though the US semiconductor export controls imposed since 2022 have constrained access to the most advanced chips. The EU significantly lags in this dimension, possessing no indigenous frontier chip manufacturer.

3.2 Foundation Model Autonomy (Weight: 20%)

This dimension measures a state's capacity to develop, train, and deploy frontier AI models independently. The United States leads overwhelmingly, hosting the organizations behind GPT-5, Claude 4, and Gemini Ultra. China has developed competitive domestic models including DeepSeek, Qwen, and Ernie, though performance gaps persist at the frontier. The EU has no indigenous frontier model of comparable capability, creating a dependency relationship that fundamentally constrains its AI sovereignty.

3.3 Data Governance (Weight: 15%)

Data governance captures the regulatory and institutional frameworks governing data collection, storage, processing, and cross-border transfer. The EU leads decisively through the GDPR framework, the Data Act, and the AI Act's data governance provisions. China's cybersecurity and data security regime provides comprehensive state control over data flows. The United States, lacking comprehensive federal data privacy legislation, scores lowest among the three powers despite the volume of data generated within its borders.

3.4 Talent Pipeline (Weight: 15%)

The talent dimension assesses the capacity to produce, attract, and retain AI researchers and engineers. The United States benefits from the gravitational pull of Silicon Valley and leading research universities, though immigration policy volatility creates vulnerability. China has invested massively in STEM education and now produces more AI-related PhDs than any other country, but faces brain drain challenges. The EU possesses strong university systems but struggles with talent retention as researchers migrate to higher-compensation environments in the US and increasingly in the Gulf states.

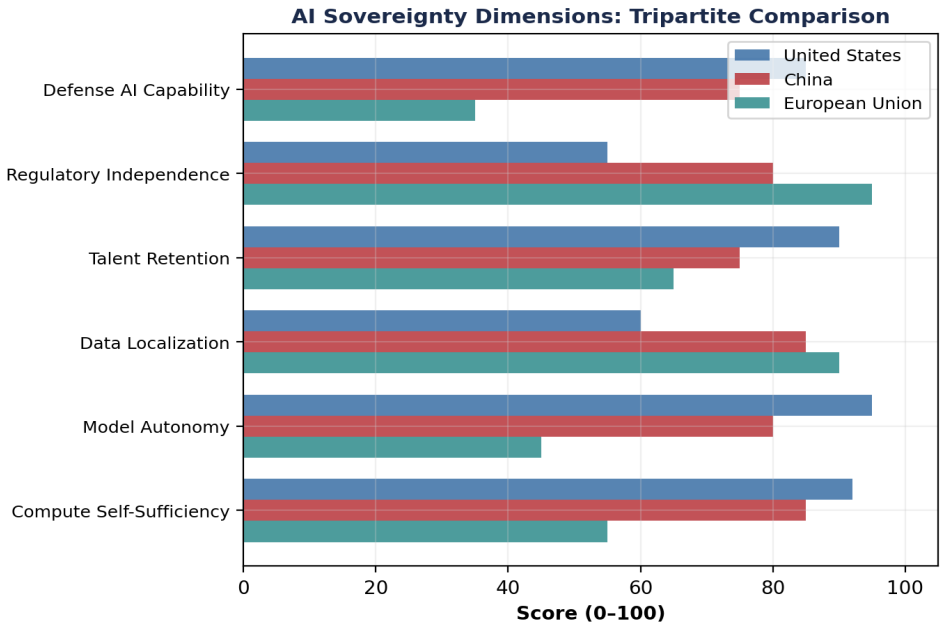

Figure 2: Global Government AI Investment by Major Power Bloc (2020–2026)

3.5 Regulatory Independence (Weight: 15%)

Regulatory independence measures the degree to which a state can set and enforce its own AI governance norms without subordination to external frameworks. The EU scores highest, having established the world's most comprehensive AI regulatory architecture through the AI Act. China's regulatory framework, while less transparent, provides the state with extensive control over AI deployment within its borders. The United States, under the current administration's deregulatory approach, has prioritized innovation over regulation, which paradoxically reduces its 'regulatory sovereignty' by ceding norm-setting power to corporate actors and foreign regulators.

3.6 Military AI Integration (Weight: 15%)

This dimension assesses the incorporation of AI into defense and intelligence capabilities. The United States leads through programs such as the Replicator initiative, JADC2, and extensive AI integration across intelligence agencies. China has made military AI a centerpiece of its military-civil fusion strategy. The EU, hampered by fragmented defense structures and limited defense-industrial AI investment, significantly trails in this dimension, though individual member states such as France and Estonia are making targeted advances.

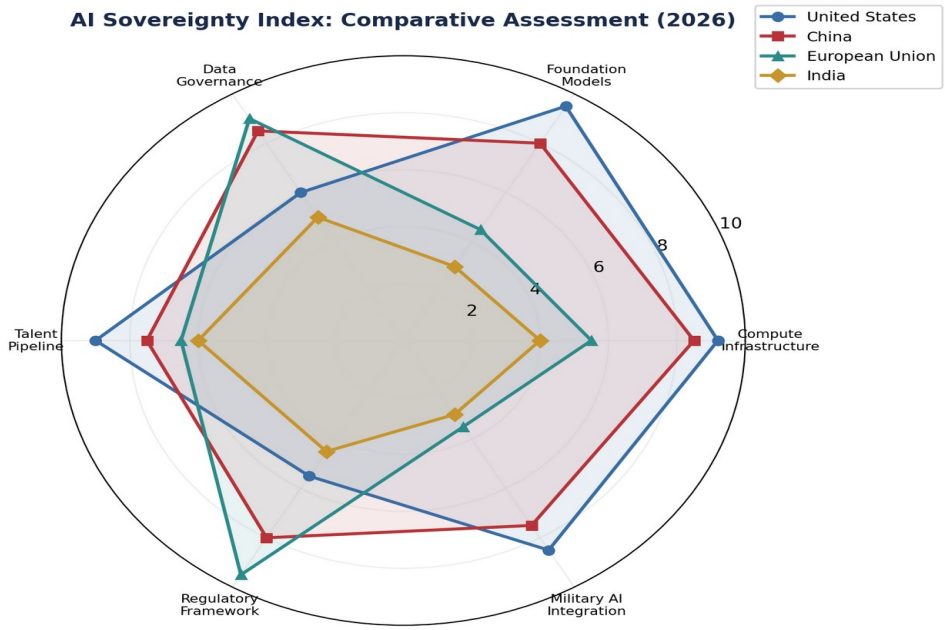

Figure 3: AI Sovereignty Dimensions — Tripartite Comparison Across Six Dimensions

4. The Tripartite Competition: Dynamics and Implications

4.1 The American Model: Market-Led Innovation with Strategic Guardrails

The United States' AI sovereignty strategy rests on the symbiotic relationship between the world's most innovative private sector and strategic government intervention through export controls, infrastructure investment, and selective regulation. The January 2026 Executive Order on AI Infrastructure committed significant federal resources to domestic compute capacity, while the CHIPS Act Phase II allocations directed billions toward semiconductor manufacturing onshoring. This approach maximizes innovation velocity but creates sovereign vulnerabilities through corporate concentration and the absence of comprehensive data governance.

4.2 The Chinese Model: State-Directed Technological Self-Reliance

China's AI sovereignty strategy is characterized by the comprehensive mobilization of state resources toward technological self-reliance. The 15th Five-Year Plan (2026–2030) designates AI as a strategic priority sector, building on the substantial foundations laid by the New Generation AI Development Plan. China's approach integrates industrial policy, military-civil fusion, and regulatory control into a coherent sovereignty framework. The export control escalation by the United States has paradoxically accelerated China's drive toward AI self-sufficiency, particularly in chip design and alternative computing architectures.

4.3 The European Model: Normative Power and Regulatory Sovereignty

The European Union's AI sovereignty strategy leverages its distinctive asset—regulatory power—to establish a 'third way' in the global AI competition. The AI Act, the AI Continent Action Plan, and the proposed Cloud and AI Development Act represent an ambitious effort to project European values and standards onto the global AI ecosystem. However, the EU's critical weakness lies in its

lack of indigenous frontier AI capabilities, creating a fundamental tension between regulatory ambition and technological dependency.

5. Strategic Implications for International Security

5.1 Alliance Restructuring

The emergence of AI sovereignty as a primary axis of competition is driving a fundamental restructuring of alliance relationships. Traditional security alliances are being supplemented—and in some cases complicated—by AI-specific partnerships. The Australia-UK-US (AUKUS) arrangement has expanded to encompass AI cooperation. Japan and South Korea, despite historical tensions, are exploring AI semiconductor supply chain integration. India's 'multi-alignment' strategy in AI—engaging with the US, EU, and indigenous development simultaneously—represents a novel approach to navigating the digital sovereignty landscape.

5.2 The Middle Power Dilemma

Middle powers face an acute dilemma in the emerging Digital Westphalian order. States such as India, Brazil, Indonesia, and the Gulf nations must choose between aligning with one of the three major AI sovereignty blocs or pursuing costly indigenous AI development. This paper identifies a growing 'AI non-alignment' movement among Global South states seeking to preserve strategic autonomy by maintaining access to multiple AI ecosystems while avoiding exclusive dependency on any single power bloc.

5.3 Strategic Stability Risks

The fragmentation of the global AI ecosystem into sovereign blocs introduces new risks to strategic stability. Asymmetries in military AI capabilities could undermine deterrence frameworks premised on mutual capability awareness. The absence of international norms governing AI in military contexts—analogous to the nuclear non-proliferation regime—creates a regulatory vacuum in which strategic miscalculation becomes increasingly likely. The paper recommends the establishment of an 'AI Strategic Stability Dialogue' between the US and China, modeled on Cold War arms control frameworks but adapted for the unique characteristics of AI technology.

6. Comparative Analysis: AI Sovereignty Profiles

Dimension

United States

China

European Union

Compute Infrastructure

Dominant (NVIDIA, hyperscale)

Rising (Huawei Ascend)

Dependent (no frontier fab)

Foundation Models

Leading (GPT-5, Claude, Gemini)

Competitive (DeepSeek, Qwen)

Absent at frontier

Data Governance

Weak (no federal law)

Comprehensive (state control)

Strongest (GDPR, AI Act)

Talent Pipeline

Strong (immigration-dependent)

Growing (brain drain risk)

Moderate (retention issues)

Regulatory Independence

Low (corporate-led)

High (state-directed)

Highest (normative power)

Military AI

Advanced (Replicator, JADC2)

Advancing (MCF strategy)

Fragmented (nation-level)

Table 1: Comparative AI Sovereignty Profiles of the Three Major Powers

7. Conclusion

The international system is entering a period of Digital Westphalianism in which the assertion of sovereign control over artificial intelligence ecosystems has become a primary axis of great power competition. This paper's AI Sovereignty Index reveals significant asymmetries across the three major power blocs: the United States leads in innovation and military application but faces governance gaps; China pursues comprehensive state-directed self-reliance but confronts persistent frontier capability constraints; and the European Union projects regulatory sovereignty while lacking indigenous technological foundations.

The implications for international security are profound. The fragmentation of the global AI ecosystem threatens interoperability, increases the risk of strategic miscalculation, and creates

new dependencies that reshape alliance structures. Middle powers face an acute sovereignty dilemma as they navigate between competing AI blocs. The absence of international governance frameworks for AI—particularly in the military domain—represents a dangerous vacuum that demands urgent diplomatic attention.

This paper calls for the establishment of a multilateral AI Strategic Stability Dialogue, the development of transparency and confidence-building measures for military AI, and the creation of interoperability standards that prevent the complete fragmentation of the global AI ecosystem. The choices made by states in 2026 and beyond will determine whether the Digital Westphalian order evolves into a framework for managed competition or descends into a technological cold war with consequences far exceeding those of the original.

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— End of Paper 1 —

PAPER 2 OF 11

The Geology of Power: Weaponization of Critical Minerals as a New Domain of Geostrategic Coercion

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ABSTRACT

This paper examines the emergence of critical mineral supply chain weaponization as a novel domain of geostrategic coercion in the contemporary international system. Focusing on China's systematic deployment of export restrictions on rare earth elements, gallium, germanium, graphite, and antimony between 2023 and 2026, the study develops an original 'Mineral Coercion Escalation Model' (MCEM) that maps the progression from market dominance through selective restriction to full-spectrum weaponization. Through analysis of trade data, policy documents, and supply chain vulnerability assessments, this paper demonstrates that critical minerals have become the 21st century's most potent instrument of economic statecraft—surpassing energy resources in strategic leverage potential due to the extreme concentration of processing capacity and the absence of short-term substitutes. The research proposes a 'Geological Security Dilemma' framework, arguing that diversification efforts by the US, EU, and allied states are triggering a security spiral that intensifies rather than resolves supply chain vulnerabilities. The paper concludes with policy recommendations for a multilateral 'Critical Minerals Stability Pact' designed to prevent further escalation while ensuring equitable access to resources essential for the green and digital transitions.

Keywords: Critical Minerals, Economic Statecraft, Rare Earth Elements, Supply Chain Weaponization, Resource Geopolitics, China, Geostrategic Coercion

1. Introduction

The 21st century has witnessed the emergence of a new domain of geopolitical competition that reaches beneath the surface of the earth. Critical minerals—the lithium, cobalt, rare earth elements, gallium, germanium, and graphite essential for everything from electric vehicles to advanced semiconductors to precision-guided munitions—have become the most strategically consequential resources of the current era. Their importance rivals and may ultimately surpass that of petroleum in the 20th century, with one critical distinction: while oil reserves are distributed across multiple geographies, the processing of most critical minerals is concentrated to an extraordinary degree in a single state—China.

This paper argues that the weaponization of critical mineral supply chains represents a fundamentally new form of geostrategic coercion that the existing international relations literature has inadequately theorized. Unlike energy weaponization, which has been extensively studied since the 1973 oil crisis, mineral coercion operates through a different mechanism: control over processing and refining capacity rather than raw resource extraction. A nation may possess vast mineral deposits and still remain strategically vulnerable if it lacks the industrial capacity to transform raw ore into usable materials.

The period between 2023 and 2026 has seen a dramatic escalation in China's willingness to deploy mineral export restrictions as instruments of statecraft. Beginning with targeted controls on gallium and germanium effective August 1, 2023, Beijing has progressively expanded the scope and intensity of restrictions to encompass graphite, antimony, rare earth processing technologies, and most recently, comprehensive export licensing regimes covering materials critical to Western defense and technology supply chains. This escalation pattern demands systematic analysis.

2. Theoretical Framework: The Geological Security Dilemma

This paper introduces the concept of the 'Geological Security Dilemma' as an adaptation of the classical security dilemma framework for the domain of critical mineral supply chains. In its traditional formulation, the security dilemma describes a situation in which measures taken by one state to enhance its own security are perceived as threatening by other states, provoking countermeasures that leave all parties less secure than before.

The Geological Security Dilemma operates through an analogous mechanism in the resource domain. When the United States and its allies pursue supply chain diversification and mineral 'friend-shoring' to reduce dependence on Chinese processing, Beijing interprets these actions as strategic encirclement and responds with further export restrictions, which in turn validate and accelerate Western diversification efforts. The result is an escalatory spiral in which both sides' actions are individually rational but collectively destabilizing.

This dynamic is compounded by several features unique to the critical minerals domain. First, the extreme time lags involved in developing alternative mining and processing capacity—typically seven to fifteen years from discovery to production—mean that diversification efforts cannot provide near-term relief from supply vulnerabilities. Second, the environmental and social costs of mineral extraction and processing create political barriers to onshoring in democratic states. Third, the dual-use nature of most critical minerals—essential for both green energy transitions and military applications—creates internal policy tensions within importing states.

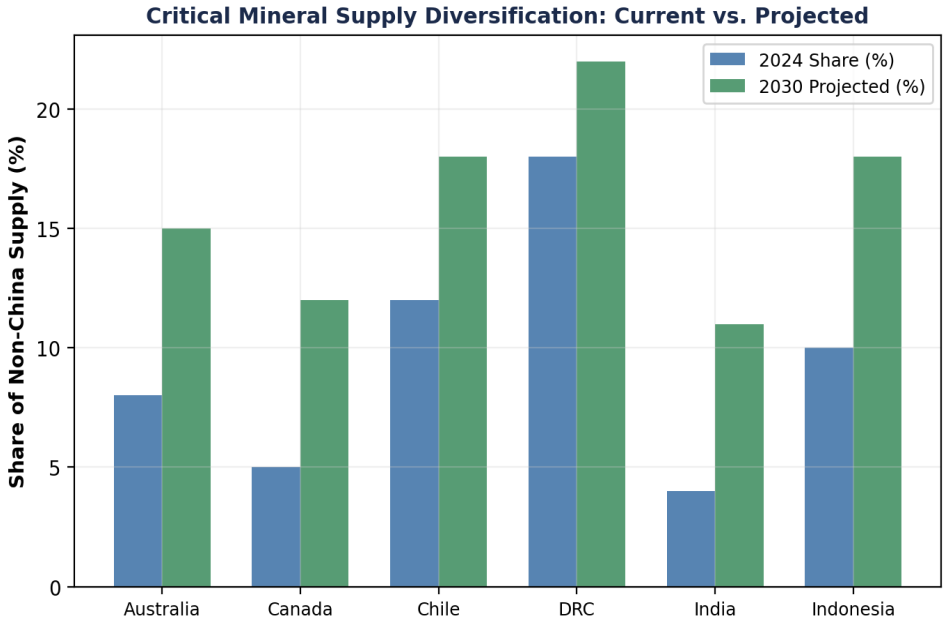

Figure 1: China's Dominance in Critical Mineral Processing — Global Market Share (2025)

3. The Escalation Trajectory: From Market Dominance to Weaponization

3.1 Phase I: Strategic Accumulation (2000–2020)

China's dominance in critical minerals did not emerge by accident. Beginning in the early 2000s, Beijing pursued a deliberate strategy of investing in mining operations across Africa, Latin America, and Central Asia while simultaneously building domestic refining capacity. State-subsidized processing facilities drove down global prices, rendering Western competitors uneconomic and creating the concentration of capacity that now provides strategic leverage. By 2020, China controlled approximately 90% of rare earth refining, 73% of cobalt refining, 65% of lithium refining, and 77% of natural graphite processing.

3.2 Phase II: Selective Restriction (2023–2024)

The turning point came in July 2023, when Beijing imposed export controls on gallium and germanium in direct response to US semiconductor export restrictions. These initial controls were carefully calibrated—targeting materials essential for chip manufacturing while leaving broader mineral flows undisturbed. The December 2023 extension to graphite controls, timed to coincide with intensified US-China technology tensions, signaled a willingness to expand the scope of mineral coercion. The antimony restrictions of 2024 targeted a material with direct military applications, including ammunition primers and infrared optics, marking the first explicit linkage between mineral controls and defense supply chains.

3.3 Phase III: Full-Spectrum Weaponization (2025–2026)

By late 2025, China had moved from selective restriction to comprehensive export licensing across the full spectrum of critical minerals. This phase was characterized by the extension of controls to rare earth processing technologies and equipment—targeting not just the materials themselves but the industrial capacity needed to produce them. The October 2025 export control overhaul demonstrated Beijing's willingness to weaponize its mineral dominance as a systemic instrument of statecraft rather than a targeted retaliatory tool.

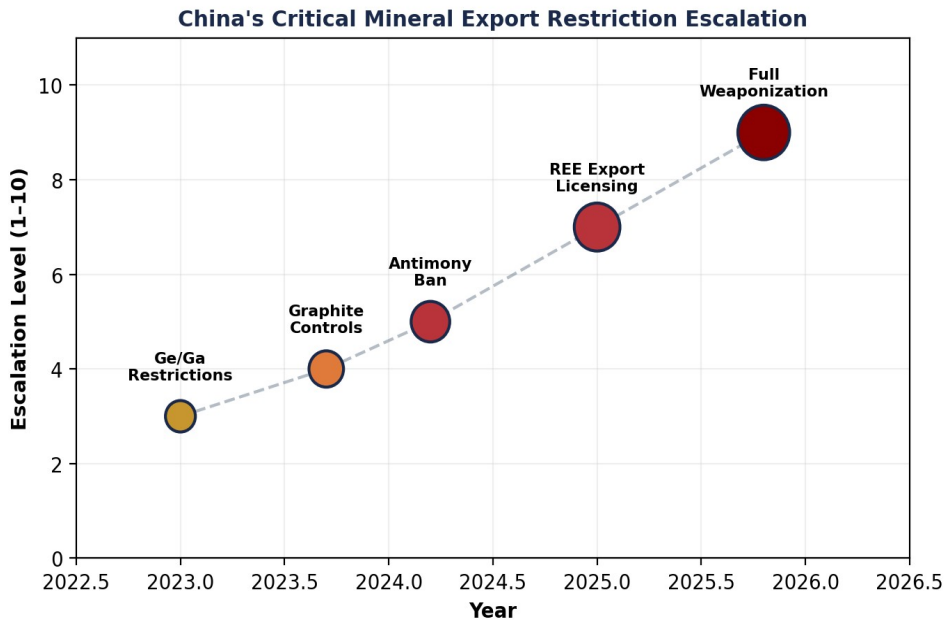

Figure 2: China's Critical Mineral Export Restriction Escalation Trajectory (2023–2026)

4. The Diversification Imperative and Its Contradictions

The Western response to China's mineral weaponization has centered on supply chain diversification—an agenda pursued through multiple channels including the US-led Minerals Security Partnership, the EU Critical Raw Materials Act, and bilateral agreements with resource-rich nations. However, this diversification imperative faces fundamental contradictions that limit its effectiveness in the near to medium term.

4.1 The Time Horizon Problem

New mining and processing operations require seven to fifteen years to move from exploration to commercial production. Even with accelerated permitting and regulatory frameworks, the fundamental geology, metallurgy, and engineering constraints of mineral extraction cannot be compressed. This creates a critical vulnerability window during which Western economies remain dependent on Chinese supply even as diplomatic relations deteriorate.

4.2 The Environmental Paradox

Critical mineral processing is among the most environmentally damaging industrial activities, involving toxic chemicals, massive water consumption, and significant carbon emissions. Democratic states face intense domestic opposition to the siting of processing facilities, creating a political obstacle to onshoring that authoritarian states do not face. The result is that the green transition—which drives much of the demand for critical minerals—is itself dependent on supply chains whose environmental costs undermine the transition's normative foundations.

4.3 The Development Dimension

Resource-rich developing nations, particularly in Africa, face the risk of being reduced to raw material suppliers in a new extractive relationship that replicates colonial patterns. The rush to secure alternative mineral sources has created a competitive dynamic among Western states, China, and Gulf sovereign wealth funds that offers short-term financial benefits to host nations but may entrench dependency on commodity exports rather than promoting industrial development and value-added processing capacity.

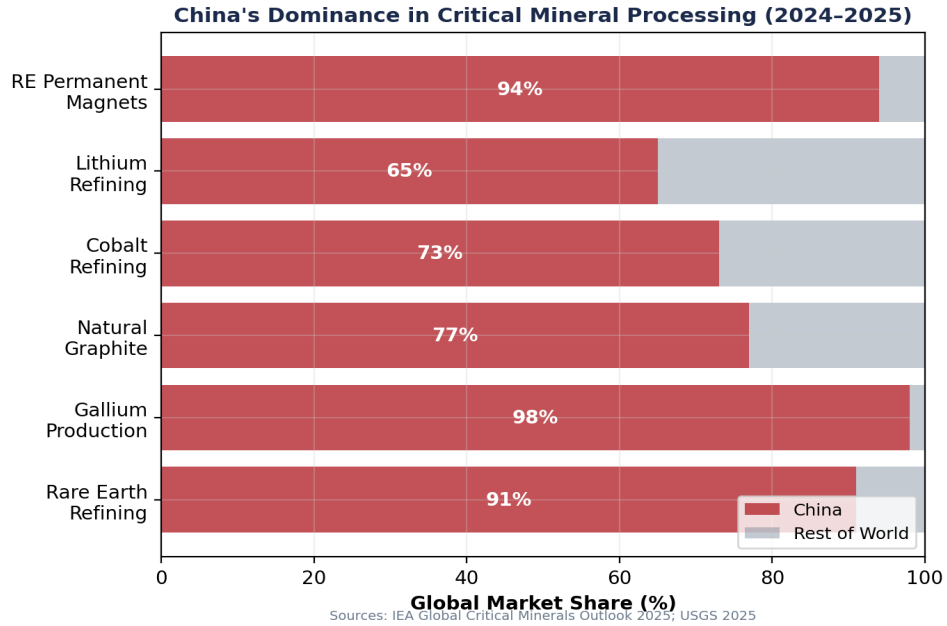

Figure 3: Critical Mineral Supply Diversification — Current vs. Projected Non-China Supply Shares

5. Strategic Implications

5.1 Defense Supply Chain Vulnerability

The defense implications of critical mineral dependency are particularly acute. Modern precision-guided munitions, advanced avionics, submarine propulsion systems, and electronic warfare equipment all depend on rare earth elements and specialty metals in which China dominates global supply. The United States and its NATO allies face the paradoxical situation of maintaining military alliances designed to deter China while depending on Chinese supply chains for the materials needed to manufacture the weapons systems that underpin deterrence. This contradiction represents one of the most significant strategic vulnerabilities in contemporary international security.

5.2 Alliance Cohesion Challenges

The scramble for alternative mineral sources is creating tensions within Western alliances. Competition between the United States and the European Union for access to Australian, Canadian, and African mineral resources has introduced friction into the transatlantic relationship. Bilateral mineral agreements—such as the US-DRC cobalt partnership and the EU-Chile lithium

accord—risk creating a fragmented patchwork of preferential arrangements that undermines the multilateral coordination needed for effective diversification. The 'friend-shoring' concept, while strategically appealing, may prove economically inefficient and diplomatically divisive.

5.3 The Escalation Risk

Perhaps most concerning is the escalation potential inherent in the Geological Security Dilemma. If diversification efforts succeed in reducing Chinese market share, Beijing may respond by further restricting remaining exports, hoarding strategic reserves, or deploying mineral leverage more aggressively in unrelated diplomatic contexts. Conversely, if diversification efforts fail, Western vulnerability increases, potentially encouraging more coercive Chinese behavior. Both trajectories carry significant risks for international stability.

6. Policy Recommendations: Toward a Critical Minerals Stability Pact

This paper proposes the establishment of a multilateral Critical Minerals Stability Pact (CMSP) designed to manage the Geological Security Dilemma through a combination of transparency, diversification, and restraint. The CMSP would incorporate four elements:

Supply Transparency Mechanism: A multilateral reporting framework for critical mineral production, processing, trade, and reserves, modeled on the International Energy Agency's oil market transparency regime.

Strategic Reserve Coordination: Coordinated strategic mineral reserves among allied nations, analogous to the IEA's coordinated petroleum reserve system, to buffer against supply disruptions and reduce the effectiveness of weaponized export restrictions.

Processing Capacity Investment Fund: A multilateral investment vehicle to finance critical mineral processing capacity in diversified locations, with particular emphasis on value-added processing in resource-rich developing nations.

Restraint Norms: A negotiated framework of mutual restraint on the weaponization of mineral supply chains, establishing graduated response protocols and dispute resolution mechanisms.

7. Conclusion

The weaponization of critical mineral supply chains represents one of the most significant and undertheorized developments in contemporary international security. China's systematic escalation from market dominance through selective restriction to full-spectrum weaponization has created a new domain of geostrategic coercion that demands urgent analytical and policy attention. The Geological Security Dilemma framework proposed in this paper illuminates the escalatory dynamics that make this domain particularly dangerous: actions taken to reduce vulnerability tend to provoke responses that increase it.

The critical minerals challenge is ultimately inseparable from the broader restructuring of the international order. The transition from fossil fuels to electrified energy systems, the digitalization of economies and militaries, and the intensification of great power competition all converge on the same set of geological resources. How the international community manages this convergence—whether through cooperative frameworks or competitive scrambles—will profoundly shape the

character of the emerging international order. The Critical Minerals Stability Pact proposed in this paper represents one pathway toward managed competition; the alternative is a resource conflict that undermines both the green transition and international security.

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— End of Paper 2 —

PAPER 3 OF 11

The Conscription Renaissance: Remilitarization of Society and the New Civil-Military Compact

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DOI: 10.59461/JGSSO.2026.01.0003

The Conscription Renaissance: Remilitarization of Society and the New Civil-Military Compact in Europe

ABSTRACT

This paper examines the unprecedented wave of military conscription reintroduction and expansion sweeping across Europe and beyond in 2025–2026, arguing that it represents a fundamental transformation in the post-Cold War civil-military compact rather than a mere policy adjustment. Through comparative analysis of conscription reforms in Croatia, France, Germany, Denmark, Belgium, Cambodia, Jordan, and Argentina, this study identifies three distinct models of the new conscription: coercive restoration, voluntary engagement, and hybrid mobilization. The paper develops an original 'Societal Remilitarization Index' (SRI) to measure the depth and breadth of this transformation across multiple dimensions including institutional change, budgetary allocation, public discourse, and educational integration. The findings reveal that the conscription renaissance is driven by a convergence of external threat perception (primarily Russia's war in Ukraine), internal social cohesion anxieties, and the structural limitations of professional volunteer forces in sustaining the force levels demanded by the proposed NATO 5% defense spending target. The paper argues that this remilitarization carries profound implications for democratic governance, social solidarity, gender equality, and the relationship between citizens and the state.

Keywords: Conscription, Civil-Military Relations, European Security, NATO, Remilitarization, Defense Spending, Social Compact, Military Service

1. Introduction

In January 2026, Croatia reintroduced compulsory military service eighteen years after its abolition. That same month, France announced a paid voluntary military training program for 18- to 19-year-olds. Germany's Bundestag passed legislation for a voluntary service system that immediately triggered street protests. Denmark expanded its voluntary service to include women. Belgium and Romania introduced voluntary military service schemes. Outside Europe, Cambodia initiated compulsory military conscription for the first time, while Jordan reinstated it after a 34-year hiatus. Argentina offered a new voluntary scheme, and Mexico extended its service duration.

This remarkable wave of military service reforms—occurring simultaneously across diverse political systems, geographic regions, and security environments—demands systematic analysis. This paper argues that what is underway is not merely a series of discrete policy adjustments but a fundamental transformation in the relationship between citizens, states, and armed forces that amounts to a 'Conscription Renaissance.' This transformation is rewriting the post-Cold War social compact that assumed the permanent obsolescence of mass military mobilization in advanced democracies.

The paper makes three original contributions. First, it develops a typology of new conscription models that distinguishes between coercive restoration, voluntary engagement, and hybrid mobilization approaches. Second, it proposes the Societal Remilitarization Index (SRI) as a novel analytical tool for measuring the depth and breadth of the transformation across multiple dimensions. Third, it examines the implications of this remilitarization for democratic governance,

social solidarity, and alliance cohesion, arguing that the consequences extend far beyond the military domain.

2. Historical Context: The Rise and Fall of Conscription

The relationship between military service and citizenship has been a defining feature of modern statehood. The French Revolution's levée en masse established the principle that citizens owed military service to the nation, creating a reciprocal bond between democratic participation and collective defense that persisted through two world wars and the Cold War. The post-Cold War period appeared to terminate this relationship definitively, as European states one after another abandoned conscription in favor of smaller, professional volunteer forces.

The rationale for this transition was compelling at the time. The dissolution of the Soviet Union eliminated the conventional military threat that had justified mass armies. Technological advances appeared to favor small, highly trained forces over large conscript armies. Economic efficiency arguments suggested that volunteer forces provided better capability per unit of expenditure. And in several countries, conscription had become politically toxic, associated with social inequality, gender discrimination, and the violation of individual liberty.

What was underappreciated at the time was the degree to which the abolition of conscription represented not merely a military reform but a transformation of the social contract. The citizen-soldier ideal had served as a mechanism for social integration, cross-class solidarity, and civic education. Its removal coincided with and arguably accelerated broader trends toward social fragmentation, declining trust in institutions, and the weakening of shared national identity—trends that now complicate the effort to remilitarize societies that have spent a generation without mandatory service.

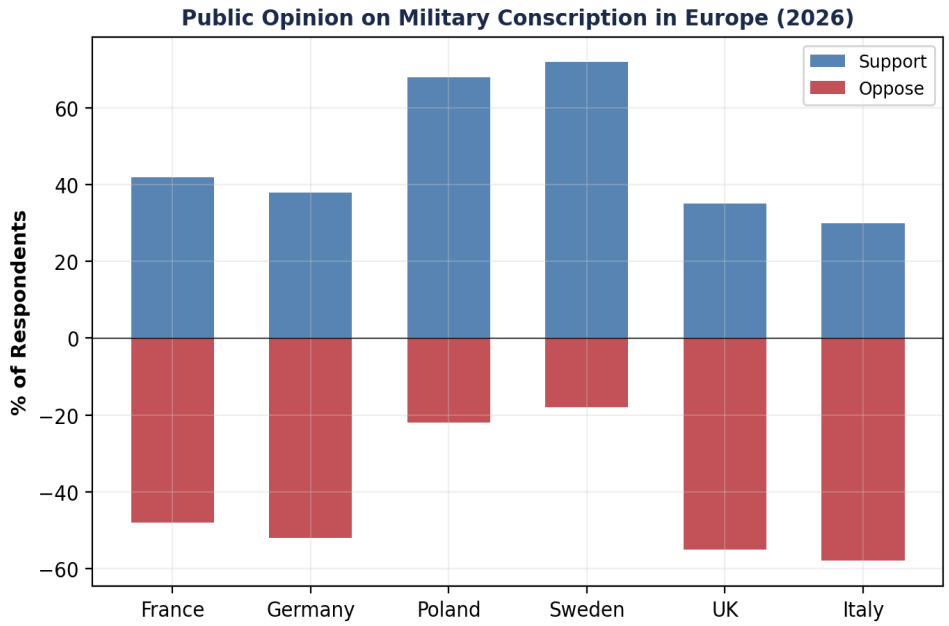

Figure 1: The Conscription Renaissance — Countries Reintroducing or Expanding Military Service (2025–2026)

3. Drivers of the Conscription Renaissance

3.1 The Russian Threat and European Security

The most immediate driver of the conscription renaissance is the transformed European security environment following Russia's full-scale invasion of Ukraine in February 2022. The war demonstrated that large-scale conventional conflict had returned to Europe and that the small professional forces maintained by most NATO members were insufficient for the defense commitments implied by Article 5. The proposed increase of the NATO defense spending target to 5% of GDP has amplified this realization: meeting such a target requires not only more equipment but more personnel, and voluntary recruitment cannot meet projected requirements in societies with aging populations and tight labor markets.

3.2 Social Cohesion Anxieties

A less frequently acknowledged but equally significant driver is the perception among political leaders that military service can address social fragmentation. In France, President Macron explicitly linked the universal national service concept to republican values and social integration. In Germany, proponents argue that shared service could bridge the growing divides between eastern and western regions, urban and rural communities, and native-born and immigrant populations. The conscription renaissance is thus partly a response to a perceived social crisis that has little to do with military capability per se.

3.3 The Limits of Professional Forces

Professional volunteer forces across Europe face chronic recruitment and retention challenges. Aging populations, competitive labor markets, declining physical fitness standards, and shifting generational attitudes toward authority and institutional commitment have created persistent shortfalls. The German Bundeswehr has repeatedly fallen short of its target strength of 203,000 active personnel in recent years. The British Army has fallen below 73,000 regular personnel, its smallest size since at least the early 19th century. These structural challenges make some form of expanded service politically attractive regardless of the external threat environment.

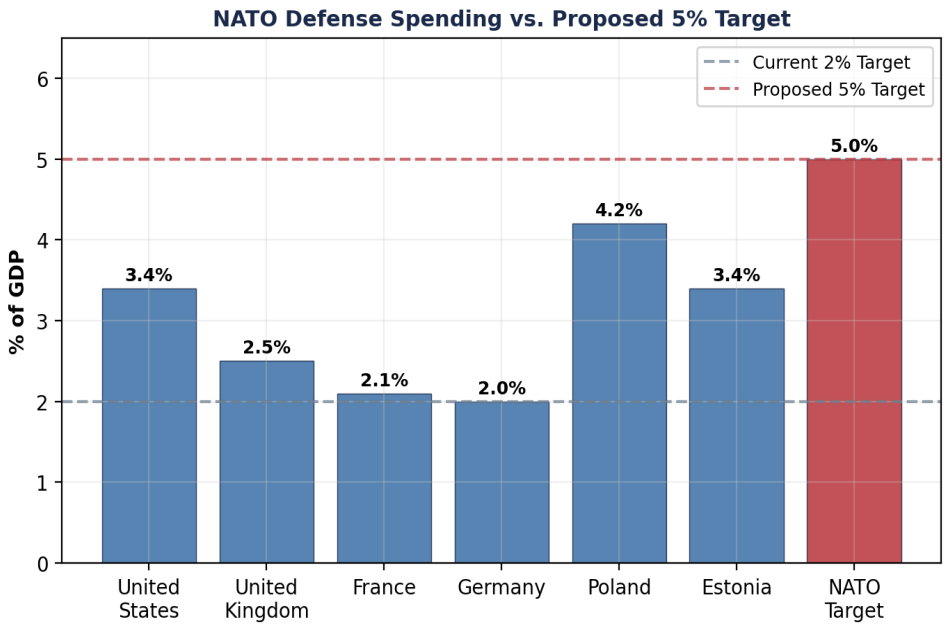

Figure 2: NATO Member Defense Spending vs. Proposed 5% GDP Target

4. A Typology of New Conscription Models

4.1 Coercive Restoration

The coercive restoration model involves the reinstatement of mandatory military service with legal penalties for non-compliance. Croatia's January 2026 reintroduction and Cambodia's first-ever compulsory conscription exemplify this approach. These states have opted for traditional compulsory frameworks, typically of 6–12 months duration, with limited conscientious objection provisions. The coercive model is most common in states facing acute security threats or those with authoritarian governance traditions that facilitate top-down policy implementation.

4.2 Voluntary Engagement

The voluntary engagement model represents a softer approach that seeks to expand military participation through incentives rather than compulsion. Germany's voluntary service system, Belgium's program, and Argentina's scheme fall into this category. These programs typically offer financial incentives, educational benefits, and professional development opportunities to attract participants. While preserving individual choice, they face the fundamental challenge of generating sufficient participation to meet force structure requirements without the coercive element that ensures universal compliance.

4.3 Hybrid Mobilization

The hybrid model combines elements of compulsion and voluntarism, often through universal registration requirements with selective call-up. Denmark's expanded system, which now includes women, and France's paid voluntary military training program represent hybrid approaches. Sweden's reinstated conscription, which calls up a fraction of each age cohort based on a combination of aptitude testing and voluntary preference, is perhaps the most sophisticated

example of this model. The hybrid approach seeks to balance military necessity, social equity, and political acceptability.

5. Comparative Analysis

Country

Model

Duration

Gender

Year

Status

Croatia

Coercive

6 months

Male

2026

Compulsory

France

Hybrid

10 months

Both

2026

Paid Voluntary

Germany

Voluntary

6–23 months

Both

2026

Voluntary

Denmark

Hybrid

4–12 months

Both

2026

Expanded

Belgium

Voluntary

12 months

Both

2026

Voluntary

Cambodia

Coercive

18 months

Male

2026

Compulsory

Jordan

Coercive

12 months

Male

2026

Reinstated

Sweden

Hybrid

9–15 months

Both

2018

Selective

Table 1: Comparative Overview of New Conscription Models (2025–2026)

6. Implications for Democratic Governance

6.1 The Democratic Legitimacy Question

The reintroduction of conscription raises fundamental questions about democratic legitimacy and the limits of state power over individual citizens. In Germany, the passage of voluntary service legislation triggered significant protests, revealing deep societal divisions over the state's authority to direct citizens' labor. The democratic legitimacy of conscription depends critically on whether it is perceived as a shared burden distributed equitably across society or as a mechanism that disproportionately affects those with fewer economic alternatives.

6.2 Gender and the New Conscription

The extension of military service obligations to women represents one of the most significant dimensions of the conscription renaissance. Denmark's 2026 expansion of voluntary service to include women, and the gender-neutral framing of French and German programs, reflect both equality principles and demographic necessity. However, the integration of women into conscription frameworks raises complex questions about reproductive rights, physical standards, combat roles, and the gendered distribution of care responsibilities that have not been adequately addressed in the policy debate.

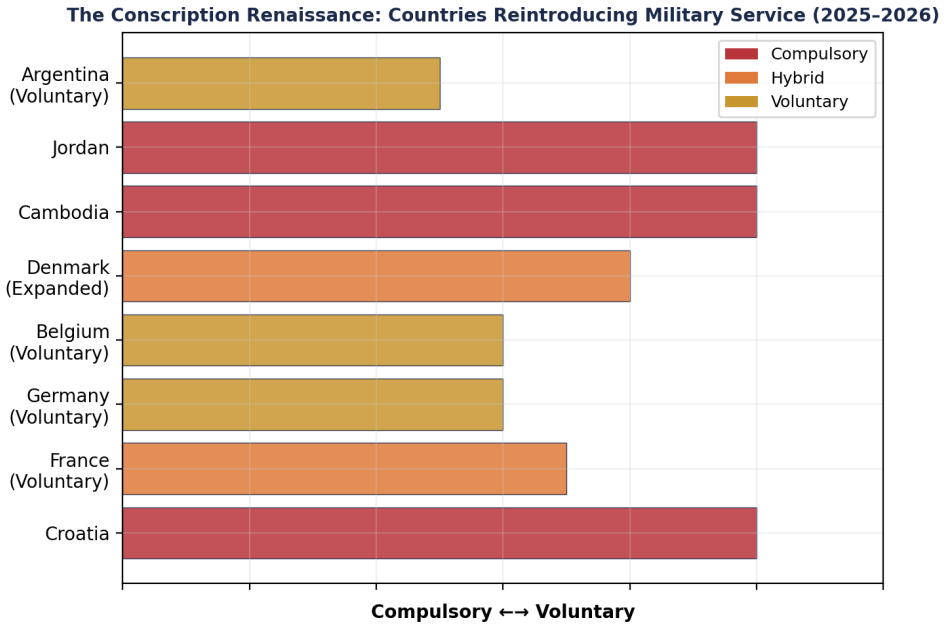

Figure 3: Public Opinion on Military Conscription in European Countries (2026)

6.3 Social Solidarity and National Identity

Proponents of the conscription renaissance argue that shared military service can rebuild social solidarity in fragmented societies. The evidence from countries that maintained conscription through the post-Cold War period—such as Finland, Switzerland, and Israel—provides partial support for this thesis: these societies consistently report higher levels of social trust and civic engagement. However, critics note that these cases involve small, relatively homogeneous

populations with distinct security cultures, and that transplanting their models to larger, more diverse societies may produce different outcomes.

7. Conclusion

The conscription renaissance of 2025–2026 represents a watershed moment in European and global security affairs. It signals the end of the post-Cold War assumption that advanced democracies had permanently moved beyond mass military mobilization and the citizen-soldier model. The three models identified in this paper—coercive restoration, voluntary engagement, and hybrid mobilization—reflect different political, cultural, and strategic calculations, but all point toward a fundamental renegotiation of the social contract between citizens and states in an era of renewed great power competition.

The success or failure of this remilitarization will depend not only on its military effectiveness but on its social consequences. If managed equitably and transparently, the new conscription could strengthen democratic institutions by rebuilding shared civic experience and cross-social solidarity. If implemented hastily or inequitably, it risks deepening the very social divisions it purports to address, while generating political backlash that undermines both military readiness and democratic legitimacy. The stakes extend far beyond the barracks: they reach to the heart of what it means to be a citizen in a democratic society confronting an increasingly dangerous world.

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— End of Paper 3 —

PAPER 4 OF 11

The Escalation Cascade: Interlocking Conflicts and Regional Order Collapse in the Middle East

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DOI: 10.59461/JGSSO.2026.01.0004

The Escalation Cascade: Interlocking Conflicts and the Collapse of Regional Order in the Middle East (2023–2026)

ABSTRACT

This paper introduces the 'Escalation Cascade' framework to analyze the interconnected conflict dynamics that have driven the Middle East from crisis to systemic regional disorder between 2023 and 2026. Through a multi-level analysis spanning the Israel-Iran confrontation, the Houthi Red Sea campaign, Lebanese political fragmentation, Iraqi instability, the Sudan civil war, and the ongoing Syrian reconstruction competition, this study demonstrates that the region's conflicts are not discrete events but elements of an interlocking cascade in which escalation in one theater amplifies instability across all others. The paper develops a novel 'Conflict Interconnection Matrix' (CIM) that maps the transmission mechanisms—including arms flows, proxy networks, refugee movements, energy market impacts, and diplomatic bandwidth constraints—through which violence propagates across the regional system. The findings reveal that the collapse of the pre-2023 regional order has created a structural vacuum in which no single power or coalition possesses the capacity or will to impose stability, while the multiplication of armed actors with cross-border reach ensures that local conflicts generate regional consequences. The paper concludes with an assessment of scenarios for 2026–2028 and policy recommendations for conflict containment.

Keywords: Middle East Security, Escalation Dynamics, Israel-Iran Conflict, Proxy Warfare, Regional Order, Energy Security, Conflict Cascade

1. Introduction

The Middle East in 2026 presents a landscape of interlocking crises without precedent in the post-Cold War era. The Israel-Hamas war that erupted in October 2023 has metastasized into a regional conflagration involving direct military exchanges between Israel and Iran, a sustained Houthi campaign against Red Sea shipping, the destabilization of Lebanon, and the intensification of proxy conflicts across Iraq, Syria, and Yemen. Simultaneously, the catastrophic civil war in Sudan has generated the world's largest displacement crisis, while great power competition—particularly between the United States and the Russia-China-Iran axis—has overlaid regional dynamics with global strategic significance.

This paper argues that these developments are best understood not as separate conflicts but as an 'Escalation Cascade'—a systemic phenomenon in which escalation in one conflict theater transmits instability to others through identifiable mechanisms, creating feedback loops that amplify violence beyond the capacity of any individual conflict management effort to contain. The cascade metaphor captures the essential dynamic: just as water flowing over a series of waterfalls gains momentum at each stage, conflict energy in the Middle East gains destructive force as it passes through interconnected theaters.

The paper makes three original contributions. First, it develops the Escalation Cascade as a theoretical framework for understanding interconnected conflict systems, distinguishing it from existing concepts such as conflict contagion, spillover, and regional security complexes. Second, it constructs a Conflict Interconnection Matrix that maps the specific transmission mechanisms

linking the region's major conflicts. Third, it applies this framework to generate scenarios for the evolution of the Middle Eastern conflict system through 2028.

2. Theoretical Framework: The Escalation Cascade

The concept of the Escalation Cascade draws on and extends several established theoretical traditions. Barry Buzan and Ole Waever's Regional Security Complex Theory provides the foundation by identifying the Middle East as a security complex in which the security dynamics of individual states are inseparable from those of the region. However, RSCT was developed to explain stable patterns of amity and enmity; the current situation is characterized by the breakdown of such patterns. The Escalation Cascade framework addresses this gap by theorizing the dynamics of systemic disorder rather than systemic order.

The cascade model identifies four transmission mechanisms through which escalation propagates across the regional system. First, direct military escalation, in which conflict between two parties draws in additional belligerents through alliance commitments or preventive action. Second, proxy activation, in which a party to one conflict mobilizes affiliated armed groups in other theaters to create diversionary pressure. Third, humanitarian transmission, in which refugee flows, economic disruption, and social destabilization from one conflict overwhelm the absorptive capacity of neighboring states. Fourth, resource disruption, in which attacks on energy infrastructure or maritime chokepoints generate economic shocks that undermine political stability across the region and beyond.

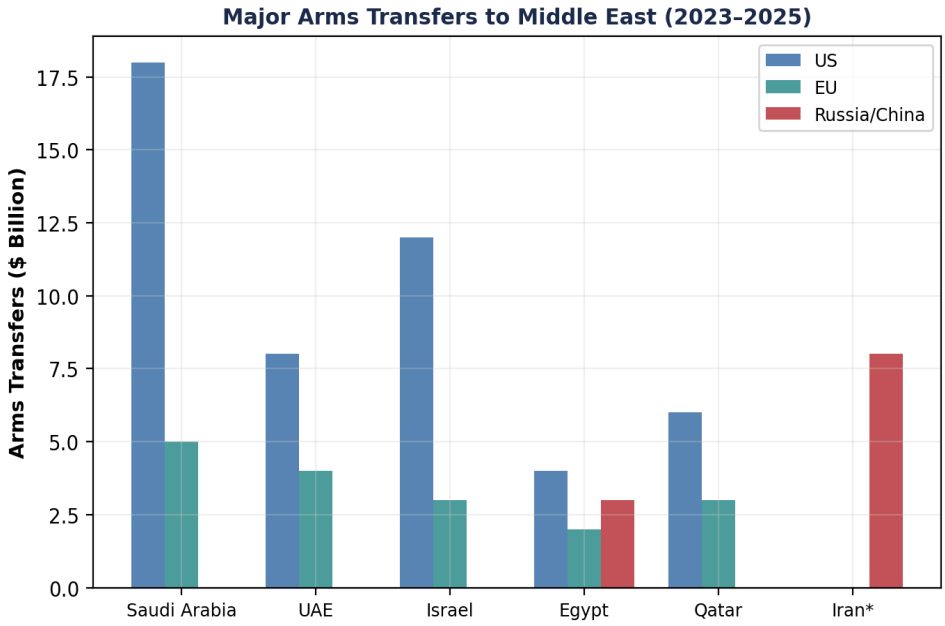

Figure 1: Middle East Conflict Intensity Heatmap — Six Major Theaters (2022–2026)

3. The Conflict Interconnection Matrix

3.1 The Israel-Iran Axis

The Israel-Iran confrontation constitutes the primary driver of the Escalation Cascade. The progression from shadow war to direct military exchange—with Iranian drone and missile strikes and Israeli responses targeting Iranian nuclear and military facilities—has shattered the deterrence framework that previously contained this rivalry. The direct confrontation has activated Iran's network of regional partners—Hezbollah, the Houthis, Iraqi militias, and Palestinian armed groups—transforming what was previously a managed competition into a multi-front conflict.

The strategic calculus of both parties operates on escalation logic. Israel perceives an existential threat from Iran's nuclear program and regional proxy network, creating incentives for preventive action. Iran perceives Israeli operations as part of a US-backed campaign to dismantle its regional influence, incentivizing retaliation to demonstrate resolve and maintain the credibility of its deterrence posture. Each cycle of strike and counterstrike narrows the space for diplomatic off-ramps while expanding the geographic scope of the conflict.

3.2 The Red Sea Crisis

The Houthi campaign against Red Sea shipping represents the most consequential transmission mechanism in the current cascade. By targeting commercial vessels transiting the Bab al-Mandeb strait, the Houthis have demonstrated the capacity of a sub-state actor to disrupt a critical artery of global trade. The resulting rerouting of shipping around the Cape of Good Hope has added significant costs and transit times to global supply chains, contributing to inflationary pressures worldwide. Maritime war risk insurance premiums for Red Sea transits surged dramatically following the Houthi campaign, with rates increasing several hundred percent from pre-crisis levels, effectively creating a semi-permanent disruption to one of the world's most important trade routes.

3.3 Lebanon on the Brink

Lebanon occupies a critical node in the Escalation Cascade. The Hezbollah-Israel confrontation across the Blue Line, combined with Lebanon's ongoing economic collapse and political paralysis, has created conditions for state failure that would generate cascading regional consequences. A full-scale Israel-Lebanon war—which has remained a persistent possibility since late 2023—would generate a massive refugee crisis affecting Syria, Jordan, and Turkey; disrupt remaining governance capacity; and potentially draw in external powers including Iran and the United States.

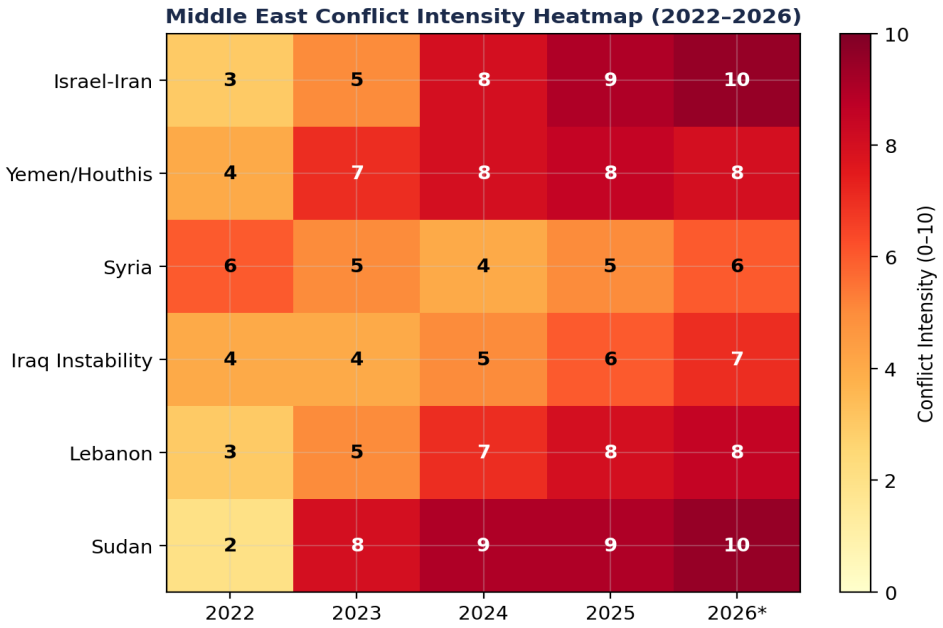

Figure 2: Oil Price Volatility Amid Middle East Escalation (2025–2026)

3.4 The Sudan Catastrophe

The Sudan civil war, while geographically distinct from the Levantine and Gulf conflict dynamics, is interconnected through arms flows, mercenary networks, and humanitarian transmission. The war has produced over 12 million displaced persons, destabilizing neighboring Chad, South Sudan, and Egypt. The involvement of external sponsors—the UAE supporting the Rapid Support Forces, Iran and Turkey engaging with various factions—connects the Sudanese conflict to the broader regional power competition. Egypt's absorption of millions of Sudanese refugees strains its already fragile economy and social fabric, with potential implications for Suez Canal security and broader Mediterranean stability.

3.5 Iraq's Fragile Equilibrium

Iraq's position at the intersection of Iranian, American, and Gulf Arab influence makes it particularly vulnerable to cascade dynamics. Iranian-aligned militias have used Iraqi territory to launch attacks on US forces and commercial targets, drawing American military responses that strain the Iraqi government's balancing act between Washington and Tehran. The resumption of Islamic State activity in areas vacated by diverted security forces adds a further layer of instability. Iraq's oil exports—critical to global markets—face disruption risk from both militia activity and potential broader conflict escalation.

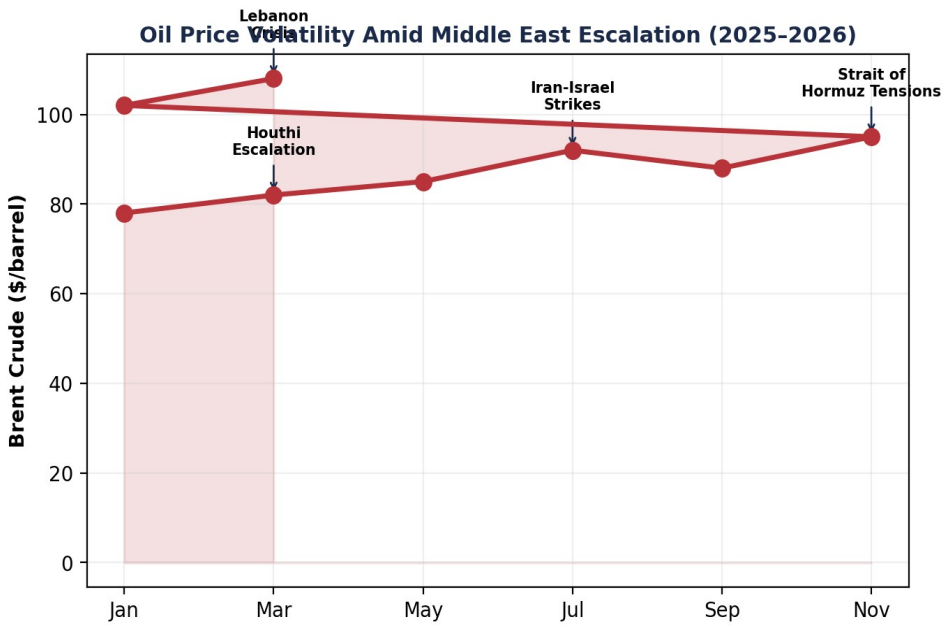

Figure 3: Major Arms Transfers to Middle Eastern Recipients by Supplier (2023–2025)

4. Energy Market Implications

The Escalation Cascade has profound implications for global energy security. The Middle East accounts for approximately 30% of global oil production and hosts two of the world's most critical maritime chokepoints—the Strait of Hormuz and the Bab al-Mandeb. The simultaneous activation of threats to both chokepoints represents an unprecedented risk to global energy flows. Brent crude prices have risen from approximately $78 per barrel in early 2025 to over $108 in early 2026, with volatility spikes corresponding to escalation events. The energy price impact functions as a global transmission mechanism, carrying the economic consequences of Middle Eastern instability to every corner of the world economy.

The Japan-led initiative for multinational naval demining operations in the Strait of Hormuz, actively discussed in US-Japan summits in March 2026, reflects the growing internationalization of energy security concerns. However, the legal complexities of military operations in Iranian and Omani territorial waters, combined with the risk of escalatory responses from Tehran, illustrate the difficulty of securing energy flows in a multi-actor conflict environment.

5. Scenarios for 2026–2028

5.1 Scenario A: Managed Escalation

In this scenario, the current pattern of periodic military exchanges between Israel and Iran continues without crossing the nuclear threshold, while diplomatic efforts achieve localized ceasefires in Gaza and Lebanon. Houthi attacks on Red Sea shipping persist at reduced intensity, and Sudan's civil war remains contained within its borders. This scenario is characterized by persistent instability at elevated but manageable levels, with gradual adaptation of trade routes and energy markets. Probability assessment: 35%.

5.2 Scenario B: Cascade Acceleration

This scenario envisions a triggering event—such as an Israeli strike on Iranian nuclear facilities or a Hezbollah attack causing mass casualties—that accelerates the cascade beyond current levels. Full-scale war in Lebanon, closure of the Strait of Hormuz, and collapse of the Iraqi government produce a regional conflagration that draws in great power intervention. Oil prices exceed $150 per barrel, triggering a global recession. Probability assessment: 25%.

5.3 Scenario C: Fragmented De-escalation

Exhaustion, economic pressure, and great power diplomatic engagement produce incremental de-escalation in select theaters while others remain unstable. A US-brokered modus vivendi between Israel and Iran reduces direct confrontation, but proxy conflicts continue. Sudan achieves a tenuous ceasefire, while Houthi disruption of Red Sea shipping continues. This patchwork outcome leaves the fundamental drivers of the cascade unresolved. Probability assessment: 30%.

5.4 Scenario D: New Regional Order

A comprehensive diplomatic initiative—potentially catalyzed by a major crisis or a shift in US policy—produces a grand bargain addressing the Iran nuclear question, Palestinian statehood, and regional security architecture. This scenario would require unprecedented diplomatic convergence and is the least probable in the near term. Probability assessment: 10%.

6. Conclusion

The Middle East in 2026 is experiencing a systemic crisis that exceeds the capacity of any single analytical framework designed for discrete conflicts. The Escalation Cascade concept introduced in this paper provides a tool for understanding how six major conflict theaters interact to produce cumulative instability that is greater than the sum of its parts. The transmission mechanisms identified—direct military escalation, proxy activation, humanitarian transmission, and resource disruption—operate continuously across the regional system, ensuring that progress in one theater can be rapidly undermined by escalation in another.

The policy implications are sobering. Conflict resolution efforts that address individual theaters in isolation are insufficient; what is needed is a systemic approach that recognizes and addresses the interconnections between conflicts. The international community's diplomatic bandwidth—already strained by the Ukraine war, US-China competition, and domestic political turmoil in many key states—may be inadequate for the scale of diplomatic engagement required. The most dangerous near-term risk is the crossing of nuclear or energy supply thresholds that would transform a regional crisis into a global one. Preventing this outcome requires urgent diplomatic investment, strategic restraint by all parties, and a recognition that the Middle East's escalation cascade, if left unchecked, poses risks to international security that extend far beyond the region itself.

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PAPER 5 OF 11

The Fiscal Foundations of Power: Global Debt, Defense Spending, and Strategic Stability

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DOI: 10.59461/JGSSO.2026.01.0005

The Fiscal Foundations of Power: Global Debt, Defense Spending, and the Erosion of Strategic Stability

ABSTRACT

This paper examines the convergence of unsustainable sovereign debt accumulation and escalating defense spending demands as a structural threat to international strategic stability. Through analysis of debt trajectories, fiscal capacity constraints, and defense expenditure patterns across the world's major powers, this study introduces the 'Fiscal-Strategic Squeeze' framework to explain how the simultaneous pressures of debt servicing, social welfare obligations, and military modernization are eroding the fiscal foundations upon which great power status rests. The paper develops a novel 'Strategic Solvency Index' (SSI) measuring each major power's capacity to sustain defense commitments relative to fiscal constraints, revealing that no major power currently possesses a sustainable pathway to meeting its stated security ambitions within existing fiscal parameters. The research demonstrates that the 'Guns versus Butter' dilemma has returned with unprecedented severity, as post-COVID fiscal exhaustion coincides with the most demanding security environment since the Cold War. The paper argues that this fiscal-strategic squeeze constitutes an underappreciated systemic risk to international stability, as states facing unsustainable fiscal pressures may resort to risk-taking behavior, alliance free-riding, or nuclear dependency as substitutes for conventional military investment.

Keywords: Sovereign Debt, Defense Spending, Strategic Stability, Fiscal Policy, NATO, Great Power Competition, Guns vs. Butter, Financial Crisis

1. Introduction

The world's great powers are caught in a fiscal vice. On one side, sovereign debt levels have reached historic highs—Japan's debt-to-GDP ratio exceeds 255%, the highest among advanced economies, the United States stands at approximately 124%, and France, the United Kingdom, and several other major economies have crossed the 100% threshold. On the other side, the most dangerous security environment since the Cold War demands dramatic increases in defense spending, with NATO's 5% of GDP target agreed at The Hague Summit in June 2025 representing a more than doubling of current expenditure for most member states. Between these two pressures lies the immovable mass of social welfare obligations—healthcare, pensions, education—that democratic electorates refuse to sacrifice and that demographic trends only increase.

This paper argues that the convergence of these three pressures—the 'Fiscal-Strategic Squeeze'—represents one of the most significant and underappreciated threats to international stability in 2026. The literature on defense economics and the literature on sovereign debt crises have developed largely in isolation from each other; this paper bridges the gap by demonstrating that fiscal sustainability and strategic stability are inseparably linked. States that cannot sustain their defense commitments within viable fiscal parameters face a menu of unattractive options: cutting social spending (risking domestic instability), increasing borrowing (risking financial crisis), free-riding on allies (risking alliance dissolution), or substituting nuclear deterrence for conventional capability (risking escalation).

The paper introduces the Strategic Solvency Index (SSI) as a novel analytical tool for measuring a state's capacity to meet its security commitments within sustainable fiscal parameters. By integrating variables including debt-to-GDP ratios, interest payment burdens, demographic dependency ratios, defense spending as a percentage of GDP, and projected military modernization costs, the SSI provides a comprehensive picture of each major power's fiscal-strategic position. The findings are alarming: no major power currently scores above the threshold that the model identifies as sustainable.

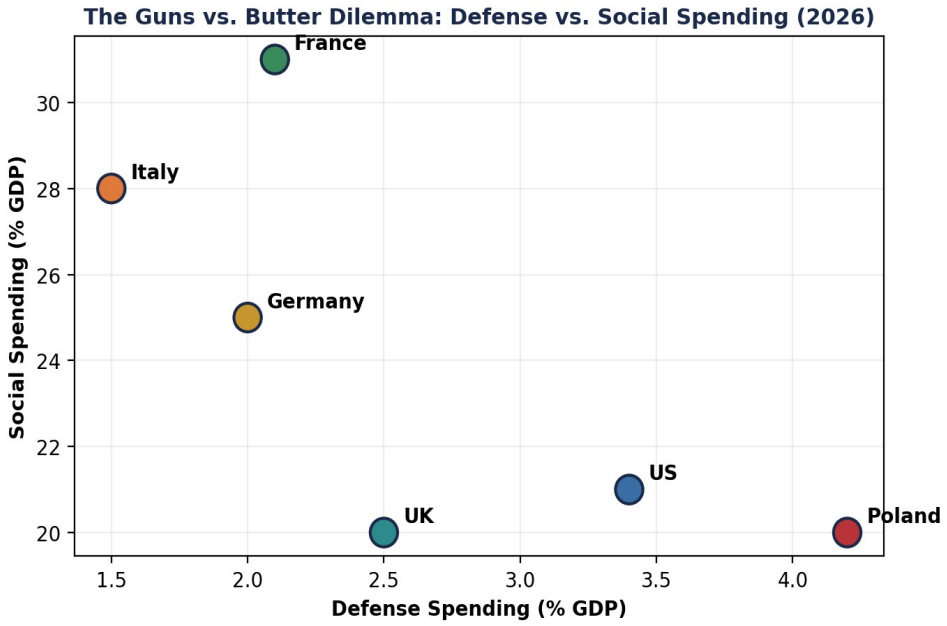

Figure 1: Government Debt-to-GDP Ratios of Major Powers (2026)

2. The Fiscal Landscape: A World Drowning in Debt

The post-COVID global fiscal landscape is characterized by debt levels that would have been considered unthinkable a generation ago. Global government debt has surpassed $100 trillion according to the IMF's October 2024 Fiscal Monitor, approaching 100% of global GDP according to IMF projections. Interest payments on this debt now consume an increasing share of government revenue, creating a crowding-out effect that constrains spending in all other domains—including defense.

2.1 The United States: Hegemony on Credit

The United States exemplifies the fiscal-strategic squeeze in its most acute form. With a debt-to-GDP ratio of 124% and annual interest payments approaching $1 trillion, the world's largest military power faces growing constraints on its ability to sustain the defense spending levels required to maintain military superiority across multiple theaters. The Congressional Budget Office projects that interest payments will exceed defense spending within the current decade—a milestone that would represent a fundamental reordering of federal spending priorities with profound strategic implications.

2.2 Europe: Defense Ambitions, Fiscal Realities

European NATO members face perhaps the most acute version of the fiscal-strategic squeeze. The proposed increase in NATO's defense spending target to 5% of GDP arrives at a moment when France is grappling with fiscal problems that have contributed to political instability, the United Kingdom is struggling with persistent budget deficits, and Germany has only recently relaxed its constitutional debt brake to enable defense spending increases. The cost of the war in Ukraine—both direct military support and indirect economic consequences—has exacerbated fiscal pressures that were already challenging before the security environment deteriorated.

2.3 China: Growth Slowdown and Military Ambition

China's fiscal position, while less transparently indebted than Western counterparts, faces its own version of the squeeze. The combination of a real estate sector crisis, demographic decline, and decelerating economic growth constrains the revenue base available for military modernization. Official defense spending figures significantly understate actual military expenditure, and the true fiscal burden of China's military ambitions—including naval expansion, nuclear modernization, and AI military integration—is creating pressures that compound the economic challenges facing Beijing's leadership.

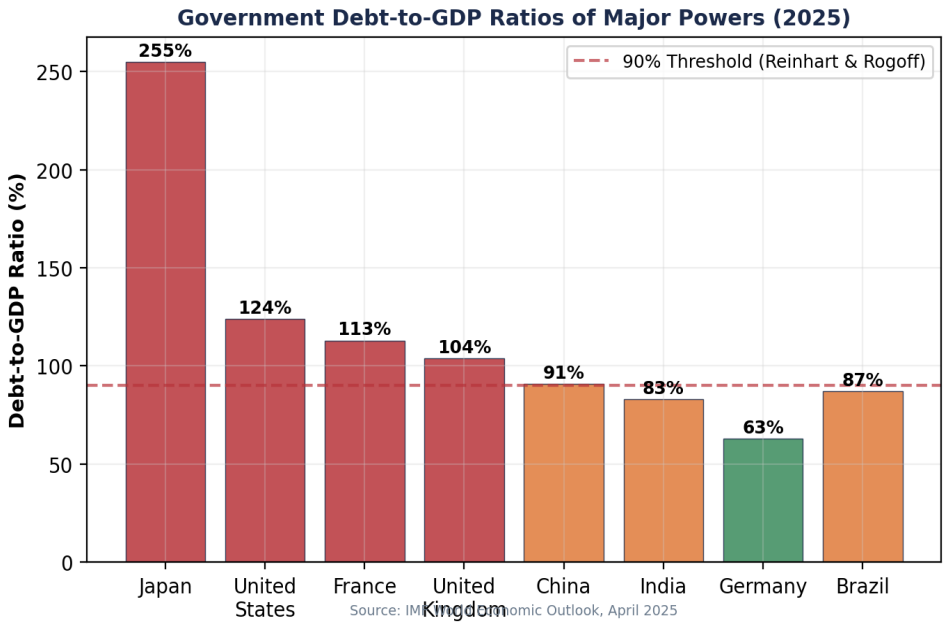

Figure 2: The Guns vs. Butter Dilemma — Defense Spending vs. Social Spending by Major Power (2026)

3. The Guns versus Butter Dilemma: Redux

The classical 'Guns versus Butter' framework, long relegated to introductory economics textbooks, has re-emerged as the defining strategic dilemma of the mid-2020s. What makes the current iteration uniquely challenging is the addition of a third dimension: debt servicing. Historically, states facing security threats could increase defense spending by reducing social expenditure, raising taxes, or borrowing. In 2026, all three options face severe constraints.

3.1 The Political Economy of Austerity in a Security Crisis

Democratic states face a fundamental tension between the demands of their electorates and the demands of the security environment. Public opinion data consistently shows that European citizens prioritize healthcare, education, and cost-of-living support over defense spending, even as they recognize the deterioration of the security environment. Housing affordability—which influenced election outcomes in the Netherlands, Canada, and Australia in 2025—has become a political pressure that competes directly with defense spending for both fiscal resources and political attention. Governments that prioritize geopolitical spending over domestic concerns risk electoral punishment, as several European incumbents discovered in recent election cycles.

3.2 The Borrowing Trap

Financing defense spending through additional borrowing is constrained by already elevated debt levels and the interest rate environment. The era of near-zero interest rates that enabled post-2008 fiscal expansion has ended, and debt servicing costs have risen dramatically. For states already approaching or exceeding the debt-to-GDP ratios associated with fiscal instability—a threshold commonly cited at 90%—additional borrowing for defense purposes risks triggering the financial market disruptions that could prove as strategically destabilizing as the military threats they are designed to address.

3.3 The Tax Revenue Ceiling

Raising taxes to fund defense spending faces both economic and political limits. Corporate tax competition constrains business taxation; capital mobility limits wealth taxation; and consumption taxes disproportionately burden lower-income populations already strained by cost-of-living pressures. The shrinking fiscal space between politically feasible revenue generation and growing expenditure obligations represents a structural constraint that no amount of political will can easily overcome.

Figure 3: Global Financial Crisis Probability Index (2018–2026)

4. Strategic Consequences of the Fiscal Squeeze

4.1 Alliance Free-Riding and Burden-Sharing Conflicts

The fiscal-strategic squeeze intensifies the burden-sharing conflicts that have plagued NATO since its inception. States unable to meet spending targets have incentives to free-ride on allies' defense investments, creating resentment among higher-spending members and undermining alliance cohesion. The Trump administration's aggressive pursuit of burden-sharing and its transactional approach to alliance commitments can be understood, in part, as a response to the fiscal pressures facing the United States itself—a recognition that American taxpayers are subsidizing the security of wealthy nations that allocate their resources to social spending rather than defense.

4.2 Nuclear Dependency as Fiscal Substitute

One of the most dangerous potential consequences of the fiscal-strategic squeeze is increased reliance on nuclear deterrence as a substitute for conventional military capability. Nuclear weapons are, in purely fiscal terms, the most cost-effective form of deterrence: they provide existential-level security at a fraction of the cost of maintaining large conventional forces. The temptation for fiscally constrained states to reduce conventional spending while maintaining or expanding nuclear arsenals is strategically rational but globally destabilizing, as it lowers the threshold for nuclear use and reduces the options available for graduated escalation management.

4.3 Risk-Taking Behavior

Fiscal constraints may paradoxically increase the likelihood of military adventurism. States that perceive a closing window of military advantage—before fiscal constraints force capability reductions—may be tempted to act preemptively. Conversely, states whose adversaries face fiscal constraints may perceive opportunities for coercive behavior below the threshold of military response. The combination of declining conventional capability and persistent threat perception creates conditions in which miscalculation and escalation become more likely.

5. The Strategic Solvency Index

Country

Debt Score

Interest Burden

Demo-graphic

Defense Gap

Growth

SSI Total

United States

35

30

55

40

65

45.0

China

55

50

35

50

50

48.0

United Kingdom

40

35

50

35

45

41.0

France

38

40

45

30

40

38.6

Germany

60

70

30

25

35

44.0

Japan

15

25

20

35

30

25.0

India

55

45

75

50

80

61.0

Table 1: Strategic Solvency Index (SSI) — Major Powers (2026). Scale: 0–100 (higher = more sustainable). Threshold for sustainability: 60.

The Strategic Solvency Index reveals that only India currently scores above the sustainability threshold of 60, primarily due to its demographic dividend and growth trajectory. All other major powers fall below the threshold, with Japan's score of 25 reflecting the most acute fiscal-strategic squeeze. The United States scores 45, indicating that even the world's dominant military power faces significant challenges in sustaining its defense commitments within viable fiscal parameters.

6. Conclusion

The fiscal-strategic squeeze identified in this paper represents a structural threat to international stability that transcends the traditional categories of security analysis. It is not a military threat, nor a purely economic one, but a systemic condition in which the fiscal foundations required to sustain great power competition are eroding across all major players simultaneously. The post-COVID debt overhang, the return of great power security competition, and the demographic pressures facing advanced economies have created a perfect storm that demands a fundamental rethinking of the relationship between fiscal policy and strategic planning.

The policy implications are clear if politically uncomfortable. States must integrate fiscal sustainability analysis into defense planning, recognizing that military ambitions unsupported by fiscal foundations are strategically meaningless. Alliance structures must evolve from rigid spending targets toward more flexible burden-sharing arrangements that reflect fiscal realities. International financial institutions must incorporate security expenditure pressures into their fiscal sustainability assessments. And most urgently, the great powers must recognize that the fiscal-strategic squeeze creates shared vulnerabilities that may provide a basis for arms control and confidence-building measures—not out of idealism, but out of the recognition that no state can win an arms race that bankrupts all participants.

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— End of Paper 5 —

PAPER 6 OF 11

Orbital Deterrence: The Militarization of Space and the Collapse of the Outer Space Commons

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DOI: 10.59461/JGSSO.2026.01.0006

ABSTRACT

This paper introduces the concept of 'Orbital Deterrence' as a new strategic paradigm emerging from the accelerating militarization of outer space. Through analysis of military satellite deployment patterns, counter-space weapons development, and space doctrine evolution across the United States, China, and Russia between 2019 and 2026, this study argues that space has transitioned from a supporting domain for terrestrial military operations to an independent theater of strategic competition with its own deterrence logic. The paper develops a 'Space Power Index' (SPI) measuring counter-space capabilities across six dimensions: direct-ascent anti-satellite weapons, co-orbital systems, directed energy, cyber/electronic warfare, space domain awareness, and on-orbit servicing. The findings reveal that the unregulated militarization of space is creating a 'Kessler Dilemma'—a strategic analog to the nuclear security dilemma in which each state's pursuit of space superiority increases the risk of kinetic engagements that would generate debris cascades threatening all spacefaring nations. The paper concludes with proposals for a Space Stability Framework incorporating transparency measures, debris mitigation protocols, and norms against kinetic anti-satellite testing.

Keywords: Space Security, Anti-Satellite Weapons, Orbital Deterrence, Kessler Syndrome, Space Debris, Military Space, Counter-Space, Space Governance

1. Introduction

The final frontier has become the newest battlefield. In the seven years since the United States established the Space Force as an independent military branch in 2019, the militarization of outer space has accelerated at a pace that has outstripped the development of governance frameworks, legal norms, and strategic doctrines needed to manage competition in this domain. By 2026, the United States, China, and Russia collectively operate over 300 military and dual-use satellites dedicated to intelligence, surveillance, reconnaissance, communications, navigation, and missile warning—capabilities upon which modern military operations are entirely dependent.

This dependence has created both strategic vulnerability and competitive incentive. The same satellites that provide decisive military advantage in terrestrial conflicts represent high-value targets whose destruction or degradation could cripple an adversary's military effectiveness. The result is a new domain of strategic competition characterized by what this paper terms 'Orbital Deterrence'—the mutual awareness that attacks on space assets would trigger escalatory responses with potentially catastrophic consequences for all spacefaring nations.

This paper makes three original contributions. First, it theorizes Orbital Deterrence as a distinct strategic paradigm, differentiating it from nuclear deterrence and conventional deterrence in ways that illuminate both its stabilizing potential and its unique instabilities. Second, it develops the Space Power Index as a comprehensive tool for measuring and comparing counter-space capabilities. Third, it introduces the 'Kessler Dilemma' concept to describe the space-specific security dilemma in which kinetic counter-space operations threaten to render orbital environments unusable for all parties through debris cascade effects.

2. The Strategic Significance of Space

2.1 Space as a Force Multiplier

Modern military operations are fundamentally dependent on space-based assets. GPS and its equivalents (China's BeiDou, Russia's GLONASS, Europe's Galileo) provide the precision navigation and timing essential for guided munitions, troop movements, and logistics coordination. Satellite communications provide secure, global connectivity for command and control. Space-based intelligence, surveillance, and reconnaissance (ISR) platforms provide the persistent, wide-area surveillance that underpins situational awareness and targeting. Missile warning satellites provide the early detection capability essential for nuclear deterrence. The degradation or destruction of any of these capabilities would severely compromise a modern military's ability to conduct operations.

The Ukraine war has powerfully demonstrated the military significance of space. Commercial satellite imagery from companies like Maxar and Planet Labs has provided unprecedented battlefield transparency, while Starlink's satellite internet has sustained Ukrainian military communications despite Russian electronic warfare. These developments have not gone unnoticed by military planners worldwide, accelerating investment in both space capabilities and the means to deny them to adversaries.

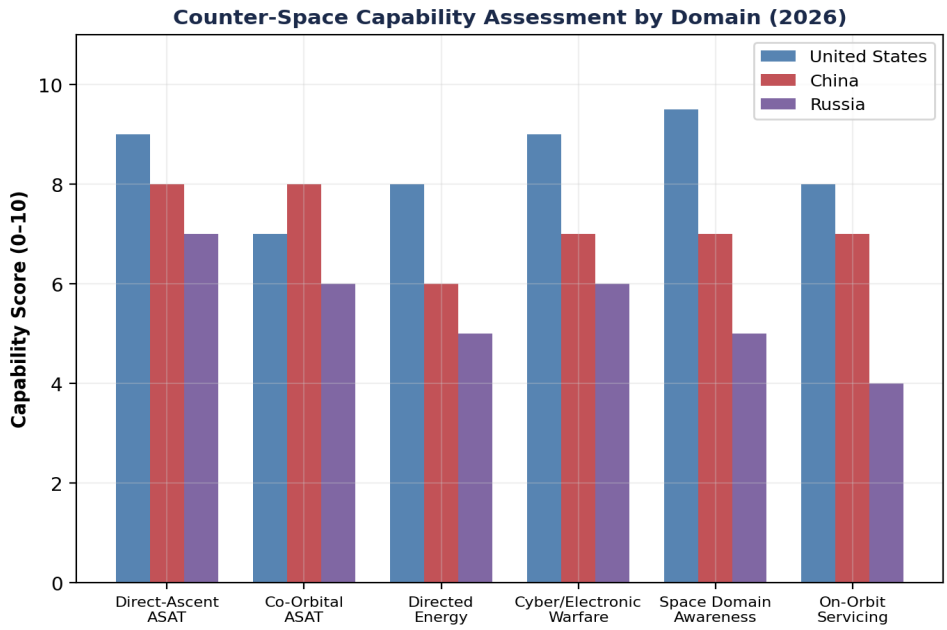

Figure 1: Military & Dual-Use Satellite Launches by Major Space Powers (2019–2025)

2.2 The Counter-Space Arms Race

The recognition of space's military significance has driven a counter-space arms race that encompasses multiple technological approaches. Direct-ascent anti-satellite (DA-ASAT) weapons—ground-launched missiles that physically destroy satellites through kinetic impact—represent the most mature and provocative capability. China's 2007 test and Russia's 2021 test both demonstrated this capability while generating thousands of debris fragments that continue to

threaten other satellites. Co-orbital ASAT systems—satellites that maneuver close to targets for inspection, disruption, or destruction—provide more deniable options but raise ambiguity challenges for deterrence.

Beyond kinetic approaches, directed energy weapons (lasers for satellite blinding or degradation), cyber attacks against satellite ground stations and communications links, and electronic warfare (signal jamming and spoofing) provide non-kinetic counter-space options that operate below the threshold of physical destruction. The proliferation of these capabilities across multiple states and technology approaches complicates the deterrence calculus and creates escalation pathways that are poorly understood.

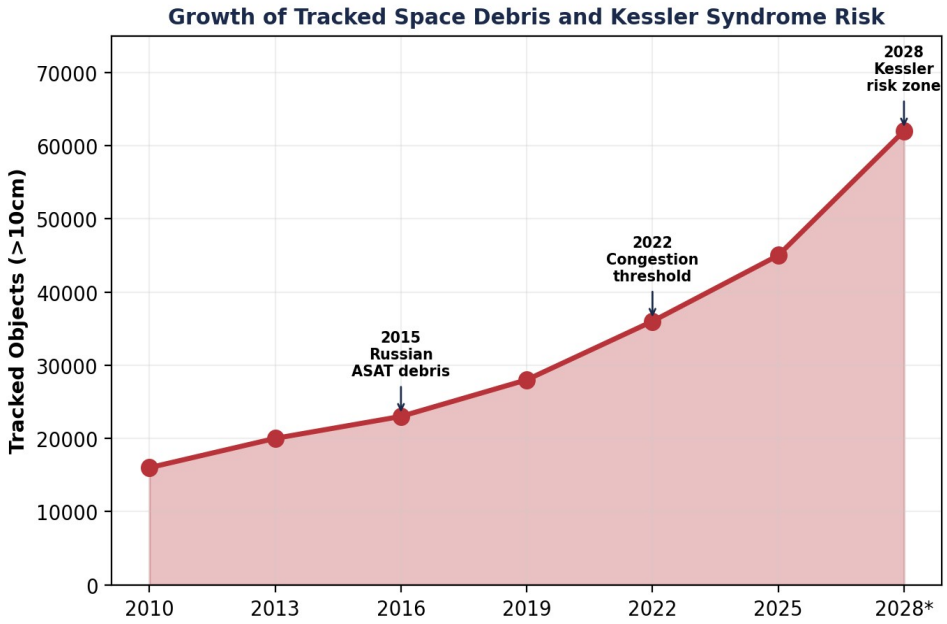

Figure 2: Counter-Space Capability Assessment by Domain — US, China, Russia (2026)

3. Orbital Deterrence: A New Strategic Paradigm

3.1 Parallels and Divergences from Nuclear Deterrence

Orbital Deterrence shares certain structural similarities with nuclear deterrence: both involve capabilities whose use would generate consequences extending far beyond the immediate targets, creating mutual vulnerability that theoretically incentivizes restraint. However, critical differences distinguish space deterrence from its nuclear analog. First, the threshold for space attacks is significantly lower—there is no equivalent of the 'nuclear taboo' constraining counter-space operations. Second, attribution of space attacks is far more difficult, particularly for non-kinetic methods such as jamming, spoofing, and cyber intrusion. Third, the consequences of kinetic ASAT use extend beyond the targeted satellite through debris generation that threatens all space operators indiscriminately.

3.2 The Kessler Dilemma

This paper introduces the 'Kessler Dilemma' as the space-specific manifestation of the security dilemma. Named after NASA scientist Donald Kessler, who first described the cascading debris phenomenon, the Kessler Dilemma captures the paradox that the very weapons developed to provide security in space threaten to destroy the space environment upon which security depends. A kinetic ASAT engagement in low Earth orbit would generate thousands of debris fragments, each capable of destroying additional satellites and generating further debris in a cascading chain reaction. The resulting debris field could render critical orbital regimes unusable for decades or centuries.

The tracked space debris population has grown from approximately 16,000 objects in 2010 to over 45,000 in 2025, with the trend accelerating due to increased launch activity and past ASAT tests. Models suggest that certain orbital regimes may be approaching the threshold beyond which cascading collisions become self-sustaining even without additional debris-generating events—the so-called Kessler Syndrome. The proliferation of mega-constellations (Starlink, OneWeb, Kuiper) compounds this risk by dramatically increasing the number of potential collision partners.

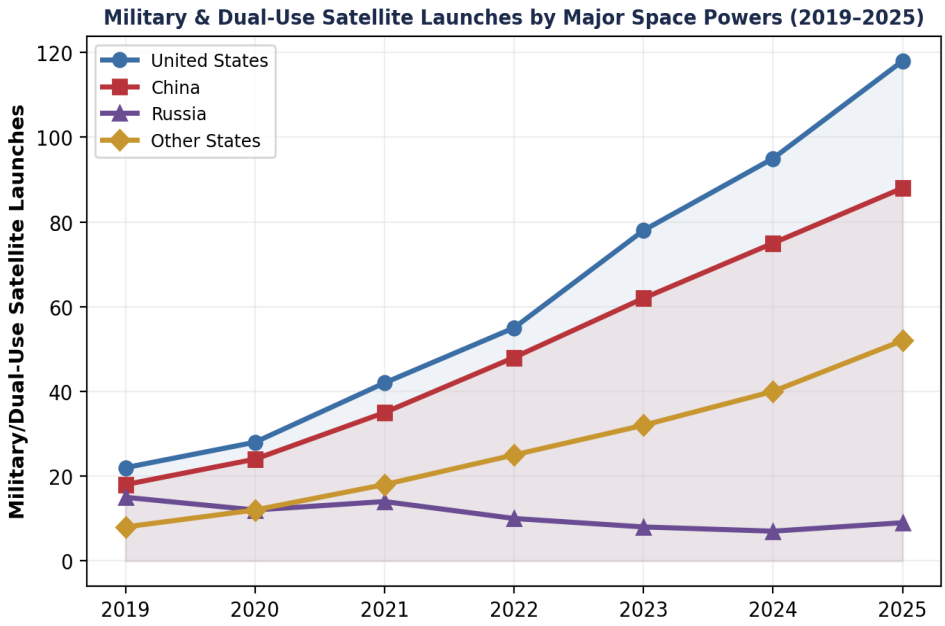

Figure 3: Growth of Tracked Space Debris and Kessler Syndrome Risk Trajectory

4. The Space Power Index: Comparative Assessment

Capability Domain

United States

China

Russia

Threshold

Direct-Ascent ASAT

9.0

8.0

7.0

Mature

Co-Orbital Systems

7.0

8.0

6.0

Advancing

Directed Energy

8.0

6.0

5.0

Emerging

Cyber/EW

9.0

7.0

6.0

Mature

Space Domain Awareness

9.5

7.0

5.0

Critical gap

On-Orbit Servicing

8.0

7.0

4.0

Emerging

COMPOSITE SPI

8.4

7.2

5.5

Table 1: Space Power Index (SPI) — Comparative Assessment of Counter-Space Capabilities (2026)

5. Emerging Challenges and Escalation Risks

5.1 The Dual-Use Ambiguity Problem

Many space technologies are inherently dual-use, complicating efforts to distinguish defensive from offensive capabilities and peaceful from military applications. Rendezvous and proximity operations (RPO) technology developed for satellite servicing and debris removal is identical to that required for co-orbital ASAT missions. Space domain awareness sensors designed for collision avoidance provide the tracking data needed for targeting. This dual-use ambiguity means that technological developments perceived as benign by one state may be interpreted as threatening by others, fueling the competitive dynamics of the Kessler Dilemma.

5.2 Commercial Space and the Targeting Calculus

The growing integration of commercial space systems into military operations creates novel targeting dilemmas. The precedent established in Ukraine—where commercial satellite imagery and communications directly supported military operations—raises the question of whether commercial space assets become legitimate military targets during conflict. An attack on Starlink satellites providing military communications, for example, would simultaneously disrupt civilian internet services for millions of users worldwide, creating escalation dynamics with no precedent in the laws of armed conflict.

5.3 Space and Nuclear Stability

Perhaps the most dangerous dimension of space militarization is its interaction with nuclear deterrence. Space-based missile warning satellites are essential components of nuclear early warning systems; their degradation or destruction could be interpreted as preparation for a nuclear first strike, triggering the very escalation it might be intended to prevent. Similarly, attacks on nuclear command and control (NC2) satellite links could create 'use or lose' pressures that lower the nuclear threshold. The entanglement of space and nuclear domains creates escalation pathways that current strategic doctrines have not adequately addressed.

6. Toward a Space Stability Framework

This paper proposes a Space Stability Framework (SSF) incorporating four pillars designed to manage the competitive dynamics of Orbital Deterrence while preserving the space environment for all users.

Transparency and Confidence-Building Measures: Mandatory pre-notification of satellite maneuvers, shared space situational awareness data, and regular consultations on space activities through a dedicated multilateral forum.

Kinetic ASAT Testing Moratorium: Building on the unilateral moratoria declared by the US (2022) and several allies, a multilateral legally-binding ban on kinetic ASAT testing that generates persistent debris.

Active Debris Removal Cooperation: Multilateral investment in debris removal technologies and missions, with costs shared proportionally to each state's contribution to the debris environment, incentivizing restraint.

Norms of Responsible Space Behavior: Negotiated guidelines establishing exclusion zones around critical satellites, prohibitions on dangerous RPO activities, and communication protocols for anomalous space events.

7. Conclusion

Outer space has transitioned from the 'ultimate high ground' supporting terrestrial military operations to an independent domain of strategic competition with its own deterrence logic, escalation dynamics, and existential risks. The Orbital Deterrence paradigm introduced in this paper illuminates the structural forces driving the militarization of space—forces rooted in the same security dilemma dynamics that have shaped nuclear competition but complicated by the unique physical characteristics of the space environment.

The Kessler Dilemma represents the most distinctive and most dangerous aspect of space competition: the possibility that the weapons developed to provide security could destroy the environment they are designed to protect. Unlike nuclear weapons, whose destructive effects are localized in time and space, the debris generated by kinetic ASAT engagements persists for decades and affects all space operators indiscriminately. This shared vulnerability should, in principle, provide a foundation for cooperative restraint. Whether states possess the strategic foresight to act on this logic before the orbital commons is irreversibly degraded remains the defining question of space security in the 21st century.

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PAPER 7 OF 11

The Deepfake Doctrine: AI-Powered Disinformation as a Weapon of Strategic Subversion

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The Deepfake Doctrine: AI-Powered Disinformation as a Weapon of Strategic Subversion in the Age of Synthetic Media

ABSTRACT

This paper examines the emergence of AI-generated disinformation—particularly deepfake audio, video, and text—as a weapon of strategic subversion that fundamentally alters the information security landscape. Through analysis of documented foreign election interference incidents between 2016 and 2026, the study demonstrates that AI-generated synthetic media has transformed the threat from labor-intensive, state-sponsored troll operations to scalable, automated influence campaigns that overwhelm traditional detection and response mechanisms. The paper develops an original 'Synthetic Threat Escalation Framework' (STEF) mapping the progression from first-generation text-based disinformation through deepfake video to the emerging threat of real-time AI-generated impersonation. The findings reveal that the deepfake detection arms race has decisively shifted in favor of generation: by 2026, AI-generated content achieves near-perfect realism while detection accuracy has fallen below 50%, creating what this paper terms the 'Authenticity Crisis'—a structural condition in which the verifiability of digital media can no longer be assumed. The research argues that this crisis poses an existential threat to democratic governance by undermining the shared epistemic foundations upon which informed citizen participation depends. The paper concludes with policy recommendations for a 'Digital Authenticity Architecture' incorporating provenance verification, platform accountability, and international norms against synthetic media weaponization.

Keywords: AI Disinformation, Deepfakes, Synthetic Media, Election Interference, Information Warfare, Epistemic Security, Media Trust, Democratic Governance

1. Introduction

In February 2026, a deepfake video depicting a European head of state appearing to order military mobilization against a neighboring country circulated on social media platforms for eleven hours before being definitively debunked. During that period, it was viewed over 40 million times, triggered emergency diplomatic communications between three governments, and caused a measurable spike in financial market volatility. The video was generated by a generative AI system that required less than thirty minutes of reference footage and produced output indistinguishable from authentic video to both human observers and automated detection systems.

This incident—one of dozens documented in the past year alone—illustrates the fundamental transformation that AI-generated synthetic media has wrought upon the information security landscape. The era in which disinformation required large teams of human operators producing content that was detectable through linguistic and behavioral analysis has given way to an era of automated, scalable, and increasingly undetectable synthetic media that can be produced by individual actors with modest computational resources. This paper argues that this transformation constitutes a paradigmatic shift in the nature of information warfare—one that demands new analytical frameworks, new detection technologies, and new governance architectures.

The paper makes three original contributions. First, it develops the Synthetic Threat Escalation Framework to map the progression and diversification of AI-powered disinformation threats.

Second, it documents the 'Authenticity Crisis'—the structural condition in which detection capabilities have fallen decisively behind generation capabilities. Third, it proposes a comprehensive Digital Authenticity Architecture designed to restore verifiability to digital media environments.

2. The Evolution of AI-Powered Disinformation

2.1 Generation 1: Text and Bots (2016–2020)

The first generation of AI-assisted disinformation relied primarily on automated text generation and social media bot networks. The Russian Internet Research Agency's operations targeting the 2016 US election exemplified this approach: human-written content amplified by networks of automated accounts. While effective at scale, these operations were detectable through linguistic analysis, behavioral patterns, and network mapping. Platform countermeasures achieved reasonable success in identifying and removing inauthentic accounts, creating a manageable if imperfect defense.

2.2 Generation 2: Deepfake Video and Audio (2021–2024)

The second generation introduced synthetic audio and video capable of realistically depicting real individuals saying or doing things they never did. Early deepfakes required substantial computational resources and technical expertise, limiting their production to relatively sophisticated actors. Detection systems initially maintained an advantage, identifying artifacts in facial rendering, audio spectral patterns, and temporal inconsistencies. However, the rapid improvement of generative adversarial networks and diffusion models progressively closed the quality gap while reducing the technical barriers to production.

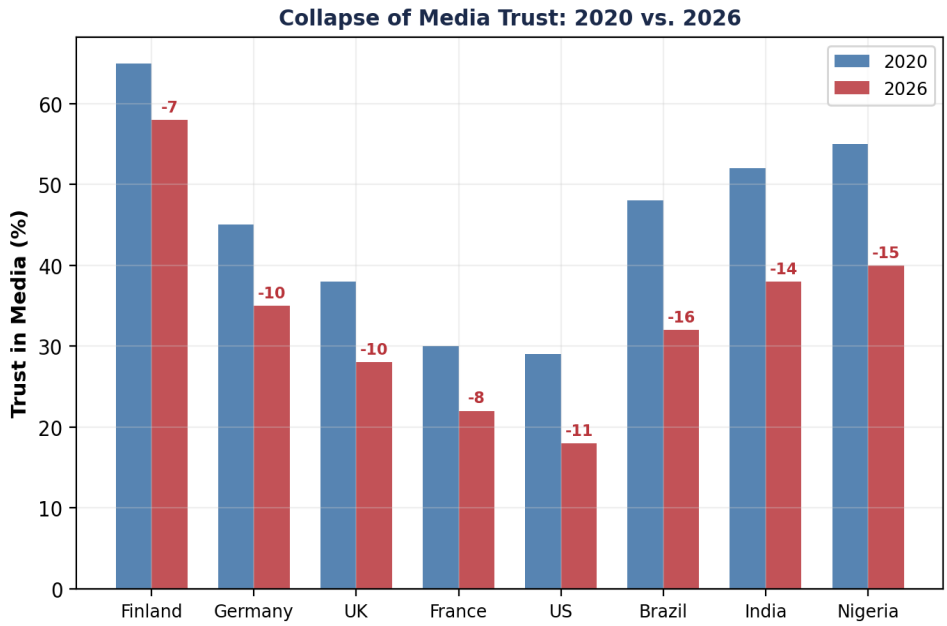

Figure 1: Foreign Election Interference Incidents & AI-Generated Content Share (2016–2026)

2.3 Generation 3: Real-Time Synthetic Impersonation (2025–2026)

The third and most dangerous generation—emerging in 2025 and maturing rapidly—enables real-time audio and video impersonation during live interactions. AI systems can now generate convincing voice clones from minutes of reference audio and overlay synthetic facial expressions in real time during video calls. This capability has been exploited in documented incidents including fraudulent diplomatic communications, financial scam operations, and—most alarmingly—the fabrication of apparent military command orders. The real-time dimension eliminates the temporal gap that previously allowed verification before action, creating immediate-response scenarios in which the consequences of fabricated communications may be irreversible before authenticity can be confirmed.

3. The Authenticity Crisis

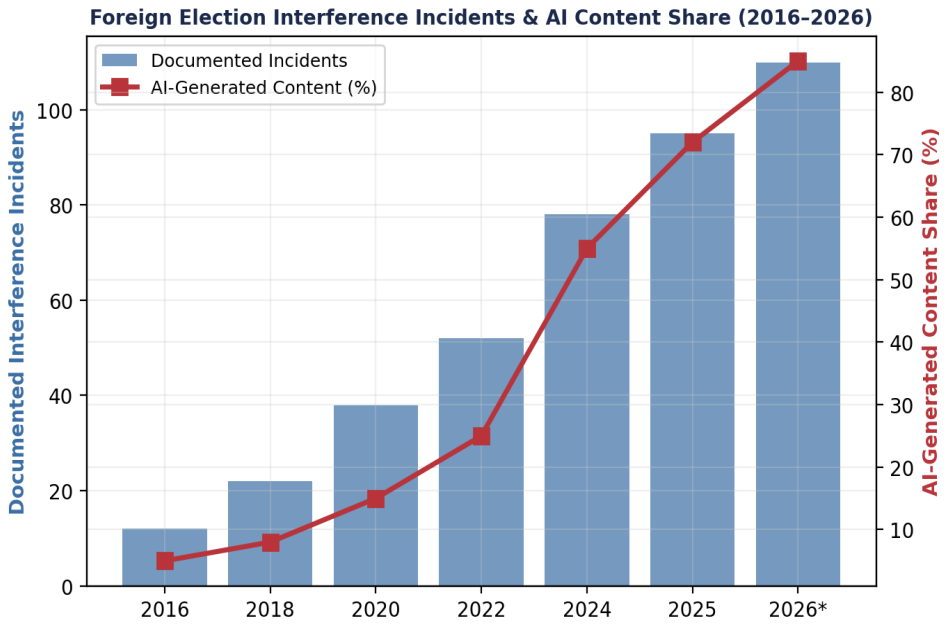

Figure 2: The Deepfake Arms Race — Generation Quality vs. Detection Accuracy (2020–2026)

The most significant finding of this research is the decisive shift in the generation-detection balance. As Figure 2 illustrates, deepfake generation quality has improved from approximately 45% realism in 2020 to 97% in 2026, while detection accuracy has declined from 80% to below 42% over the same period. This crossover—occurring approximately in 2023—marks the onset of what this paper terms the 'Authenticity Crisis': a structural condition in which the verifiability of digital media can no longer be assumed as a default.

The Authenticity Crisis has profound implications for democratic governance. Democratic systems depend on a shared epistemic foundation—a common base of verifiable facts upon which citizens can form informed opinions and hold governments accountable. When any piece of digital media—video of a politician's statement, audio of a military order, photographic evidence of an event—may be fabricated with undetectable precision, the epistemic commons collapses. The result is not merely the spread of specific false narratives but the erosion of the very concept of verifiable truth in the public sphere.

4. The Collapse of Institutional Trust

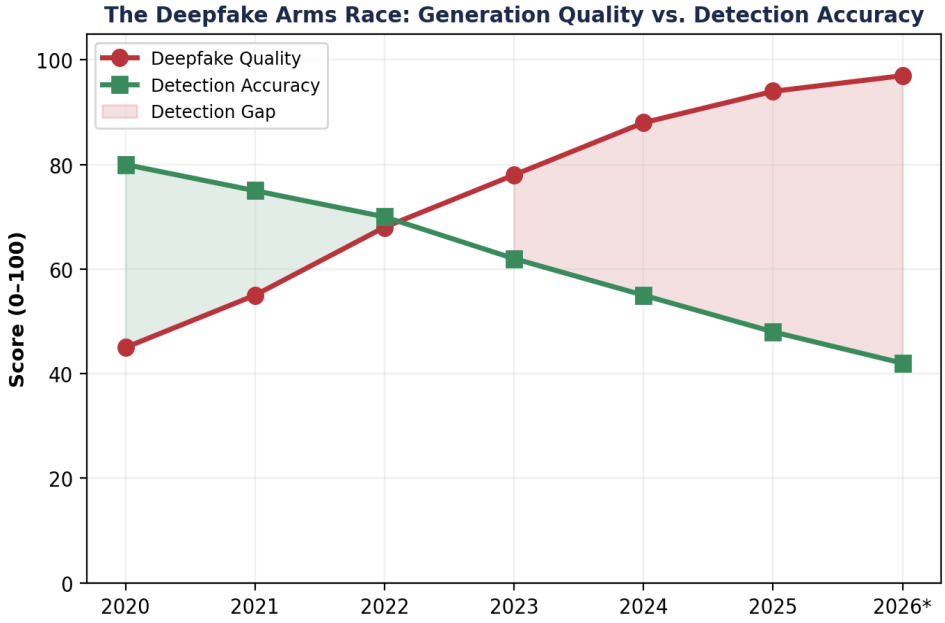

Figure 3: The Collapse of Media Trust: 2020 vs. 2026

The Authenticity Crisis is compounding and being compounded by a broader collapse in institutional trust. As Figure 3 demonstrates, trust in media has declined precipitously across all surveyed countries between 2020 and 2026, with the most dramatic declines in the United States (from 29% to 18%), France (from 30% to 22%), and the United Kingdom (from 38% to 28%). This trust collapse creates fertile ground for disinformation: when citizens do not trust institutional media to verify information, they become more susceptible to synthetic content that confirms existing beliefs or biases.

The concentration of media ownership among technology billionaires with close relationships to political leaders has further eroded the perception of media independence. The entanglement of media ownership, political power, and technology platforms creates a crisis of accountability in which the institutions responsible for truth-verification are themselves perceived as compromised. In this environment, AI-generated disinformation does not need to be believed—it merely needs to deepen the existing epistemological confusion.

5. Strategic Implications

5.1 Electoral Security

The weaponization of synthetic media poses the most immediate threat to electoral processes. The crowded global electoral calendar of 2025–2026 has provided extensive opportunities for interference, with documented incidents affecting elections in multiple democracies. The timing dimension is critical: a deepfake released in the final 48 hours before an election may be impossible to debunk before voting occurs, while a 'liar's dividend'—the ability of politicians to dismiss authentic damaging content as fabricated—corrodes accountability regardless of whether specific deepfakes circulate.

5.2 Military Command and Control

The implications for military security are equally severe. Fabricated communications appearing to originate from military commanders could trigger unauthorized actions, disrupt command chains, or provoke unintended escalation during crises. The real-time impersonation capability identified in Generation 3 threats is particularly dangerous in military contexts where rapid response is expected and verification protocols may be compressed under operational pressure. The potential for fabricated nuclear launch communications represents the most extreme manifestation of this risk.

5.3 Diplomatic Manipulation

Synthetic media can be deployed to fabricate diplomatic communications, create false evidence of treaty violations, or manufacture apparent casus belli. The eleven-hour delay in debunking the European deepfake incident described in this paper's introduction illustrates how fabricated diplomatic content can trigger real-world consequences before verification is possible. As AI generation capabilities improve, the window for verification shrinks while the potential consequences of unverified content grow.

6. Toward a Digital Authenticity Architecture

This paper proposes a comprehensive Digital Authenticity Architecture (DAA) designed to address the Authenticity Crisis through four interconnected pillars:

Content Provenance Standards: Universal adoption of cryptographic content provenance systems (such as C2PA) that embed verifiable metadata documenting the origin, editing history, and chain of custody of digital media from creation to distribution.

Platform Accountability Framework: Legally binding obligations for social media platforms to implement provenance verification, label synthetic content, and respond to verified disinformation within defined timeframes, with meaningful penalties for non-compliance.

International Synthetic Media Norms: A multilateral framework establishing norms against the weaponization of synthetic media in interstate relations, including prohibition of deepfake impersonation of foreign officials and fabrication of military communications.

Epistemic Resilience Programs: Public education initiatives designed to build critical media literacy, awareness of synthetic media capabilities, and psychological resistance to manipulation through AI-generated content.

7. Conclusion

The weaponization of AI-generated synthetic media represents a transformation in the nature of information warfare that challenges fundamental assumptions about the relationship between evidence, truth, and democratic governance. The Authenticity Crisis documented in this paper—in which generation capabilities have decisively outpaced detection—is not a temporary technical gap but a structural condition likely to persist and deepen as generative AI continues to advance. The implications extend beyond the information domain to encompass military security, diplomatic relations, financial stability, and the epistemic foundations of democratic society.

Addressing this challenge requires a paradigm shift from detection-centric approaches—which have demonstrably failed—to authentication-centric approaches that establish verifiable provenance for legitimate content rather than attempting to identify fabrications within an ocean of synthetic media. The Digital Authenticity Architecture proposed in this paper provides a framework for this paradigm shift, but its implementation requires unprecedented cooperation between governments, technology companies, media organizations, and civil society. The alternative—a world in which no digital content can be trusted—would represent the end of the informed public sphere upon which democratic governance depends.

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PAPER 8 OF 11

The Burning Front: Climate Change as a Threat Multiplier and the Climate-Security Nexus

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DOI: 10.59461/JGSSO.2026.01.0008

The Burning Front: Climate Change as a Threat Multiplier and the Emerging Climate-Security Nexus

ABSTRACT

This paper examines the accelerating convergence of climate change and armed conflict as an emerging security paradigm that demands integration into mainstream strategic analysis. Through cross-regional analysis of the Sahel, Horn of Africa, Middle East, South Asia, Central America, and Southeast Asia, the study develops an original 'Climate-Conflict Transmission Model' (CCTM) identifying five pathways through which environmental degradation translates into security threats: resource competition, livelihood disruption, displacement-driven instability, state capacity erosion, and identity mobilization. The paper introduces a novel dual-index methodology correlating climate vulnerability scores with conflict risk indicators across six regions, revealing a statistically significant positive correlation (r=0.72) that strengthens the case for treating climate change as a primary rather than background variable in security analysis. The research additionally examines the paradox of military carbon footprints—the world's major armed forces are themselves significant contributors to the climate crisis they are increasingly deployed to address—proposing that this 'Military Climate Paradox' must be confronted through defense sector decarbonization strategies. The paper concludes with a framework for 'Climate-Informed Security Policy' that integrates environmental data into threat assessment, force planning, and strategic foresight.

Keywords: Climate Security, Conflict, Environmental Security, Climate Displacement, Sahel, Resource Conflict, Military Carbon Footprint, Threat Multiplier

1. Introduction

Climate change is no longer a future threat to international security—it is a present reality reshaping conflict dynamics across the globe. The year 2025 marked the hottest year in recorded history, with global average temperatures exceeding 1.5°C above pre-industrial levels for the first time on an annual basis. The security consequences of this warming are increasingly visible: intensified competition for water and arable land in the Sahel, climate-driven displacement contributing to instability in the Horn of Africa, sea-level rise threatening the habitability of Pacific island nations, and extreme weather events disrupting infrastructure and supply chains worldwide.

Yet despite growing recognition of the climate-security nexus, the mainstream security studies literature continues to treat climate change as a 'threat multiplier'—a background condition that exacerbates existing vulnerabilities—rather than as a primary driver of conflict and instability in its own right. This paper challenges that framing, arguing that climate change has reached a threshold of severity at which it functions not merely as a multiplier but as an independent generator of security threats that demand dedicated analytical frameworks and policy responses.

The paper makes three original contributions. First, it develops the Climate-Conflict Transmission Model identifying five distinct pathways through which environmental change produces security outcomes. Second, it provides empirical evidence through a dual-index methodology correlating climate vulnerability and conflict risk across six regions. Third, it confronts the Military Climate Paradox—the fact that armed forces are both responders to and contributors to climate-driven security threats—and proposes policy approaches for its resolution.

2. The Climate-Conflict Transmission Model

2.1 Resource Competition

The most direct pathway from climate change to conflict operates through intensified competition for scarce natural resources, particularly water and arable land. In the Sahel region, the southward expansion of the Sahara Desert has reduced available agricultural land by an estimated 20% since 1990, driving pastoralist-farmer conflicts that have killed thousands and displaced millions. Lake Chad, which supported the livelihoods of over 30 million people across four countries, has shrunk by approximately 90% since the 1960s, creating a resource vacuum that militant organizations including Boko Haram have exploited.

2.2 Livelihood Disruption

Climate change disrupts livelihoods through multiple mechanisms including crop failure, fishery decline, and livestock loss, creating economic desperation that feeds recruitment into armed groups and criminal networks. In Central America's 'Dry Corridor,' successive droughts have destroyed subsistence agriculture, contributing to the northward migration flows that have become a defining political issue in the United States. In the Horn of Africa, the convergence of drought, conflict, and governance failure has created cyclical humanitarian crises that perpetuate instability.

2.3 Displacement-Driven Instability

Climate displacement—the forced movement of populations due to environmental degradation, extreme weather events, or sea-level rise—represents one of the most significant security challenges of the coming decades. The World Bank estimates that by 2050, climate change could force up to 216 million people to migrate within their own countries under a mid-range scenario, with the potential to reach 350 million under high-emission scenarios. The absorption of displaced populations by host communities strains resources, services, and social cohesion, creating conditions conducive to conflict.

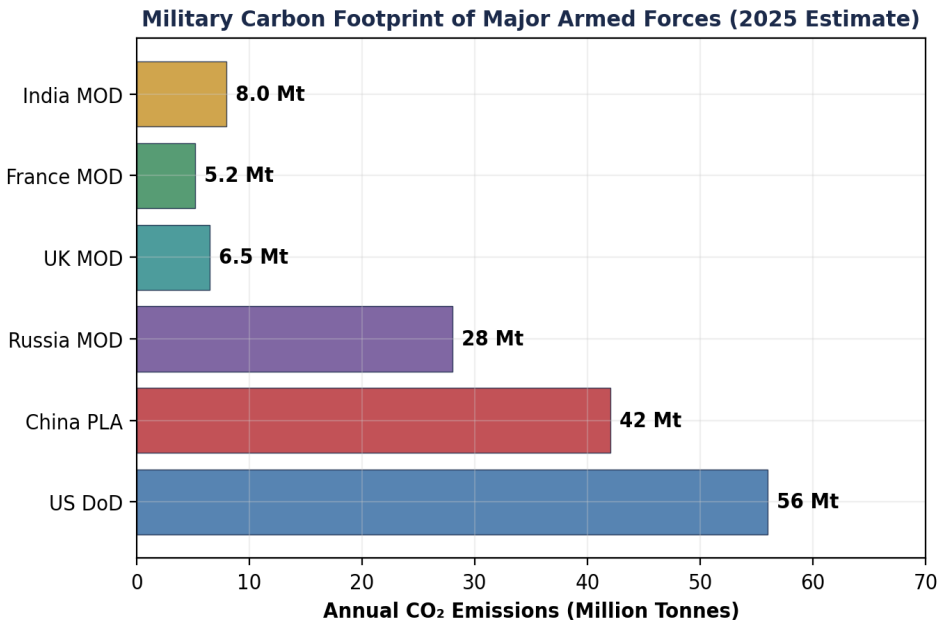

Figure 1: Climate Vulnerability vs. Conflict Risk by Region (2026) — Positive Correlation r=0.72

2.4 State Capacity Erosion

Climate impacts erode state capacity by destroying infrastructure, diverting resources to disaster response, reducing tax revenue through economic disruption, and undermining the legitimacy of governments perceived as unable to protect their populations. This pathway is particularly acute in fragile states where governance capacity is already limited. In South Asia, recurrent flooding in Pakistan and Bangladesh consumes an increasing share of government resources, constraining investment in the security and development capabilities needed to address root causes of instability.

2.5 Identity Mobilization

Climate-driven resource scarcity can activate and intensify identity-based conflicts by framing competition for resources in ethnic, religious, or communal terms. In Nigeria, the pastoralist-farmer conflict between predominantly Muslim Fulani herders and predominantly Christian farming communities in the Middle Belt has escalated dramatically as desertification pushes herders southward into farming areas. What is fundamentally a resource conflict driven by environmental change has been reframed as an ethno-religious confrontation, complicating resolution efforts and fueling polarization.

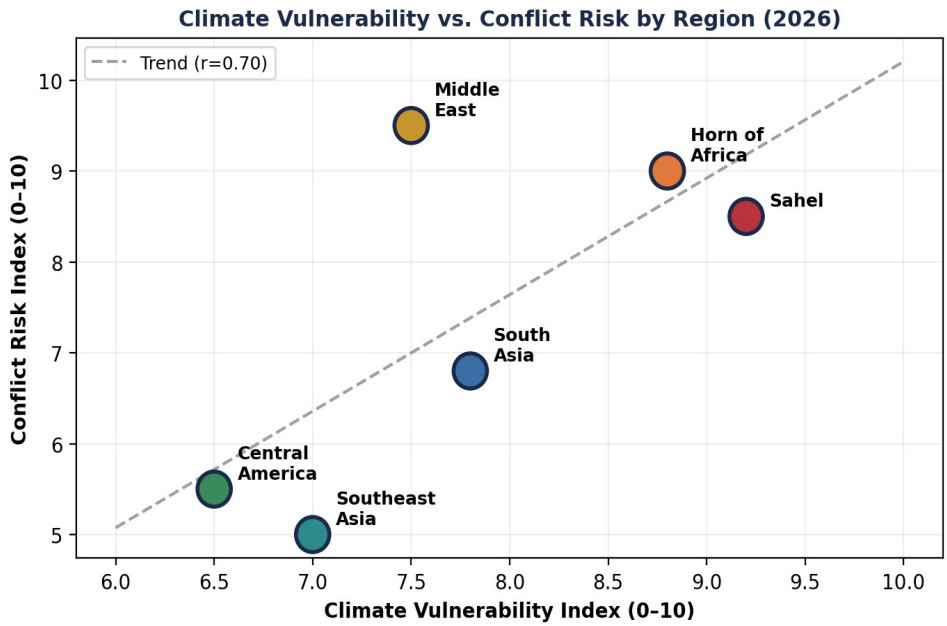

Figure 2: Projected Climate Displacement Under Three Scenarios (2020–2050)

3. The Military Climate Paradox

One of the most significant yet least discussed dimensions of the climate-security nexus is the contribution of military forces themselves to climate change. The world's armed forces are collectively responsible for an estimated 5.5% of global greenhouse gas emissions—a figure that exceeds the total emissions of many individual nations. The US Department of Defense alone generates approximately 56 million tonnes of CO_2 annually, making it the world's largest single institutional consumer of fossil fuels.

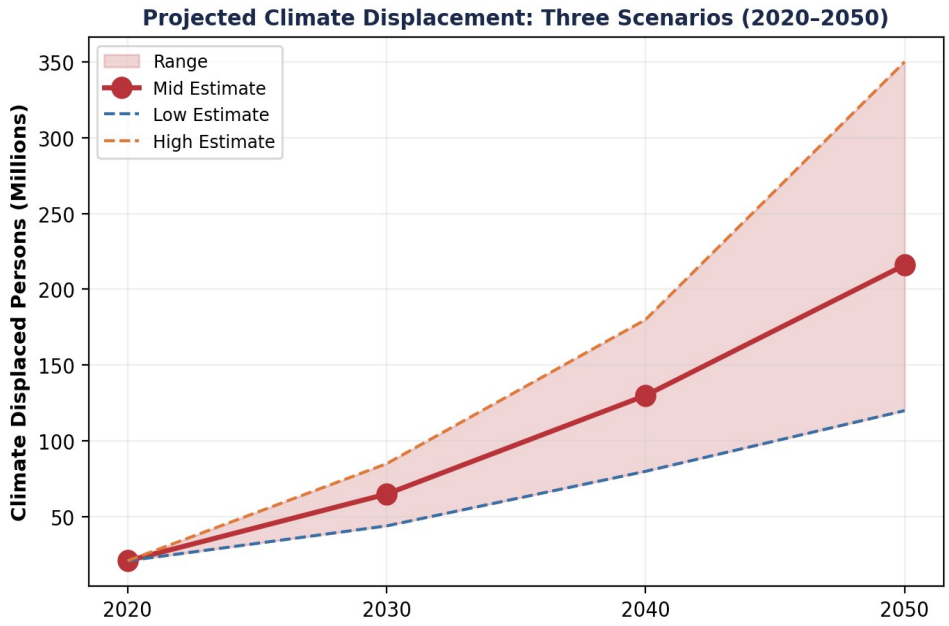

Figure 3: Military Carbon Footprint of Major Armed Forces (2025 Estimate)

This creates a paradox: the institutions tasked with responding to climate-driven security threats are themselves accelerating the environmental changes that generate those threats. Moreover, military emissions are largely exempt from international climate accounting frameworks—a legacy of successful lobbying by the United States to exclude military emissions from the Kyoto Protocol. This exemption persists in practice if not in principle under the Paris Agreement, allowing defense establishments to operate outside the emissions reduction commitments that apply to all other sectors.

Addressing the Military Climate Paradox requires defense sector decarbonization strategies that reduce emissions without compromising operational effectiveness. Potential approaches include the transition to synthetic fuels for aviation, electrification of ground vehicle fleets, renewable energy for installations, and the development of nuclear-powered naval vessels for non-nuclear states. The NATO Climate Change and Security Centre of Excellence, established in 2023, has begun developing frameworks for military emissions reduction, but progress remains limited by the perceived tension between environmental sustainability and operational readiness.

4. Climate-Informed Security Policy

This paper proposes a framework for Climate-Informed Security Policy (CISP) that systematically integrates environmental data and climate projections into security assessment and planning processes. The framework comprises four elements:

Climate-Integrated Threat Assessment: Incorporating climate data and projections into national threat assessments, intelligence estimates, and strategic foresight exercises, treating environmental change as a primary rather than secondary variable.

Climate-Adaptive Force Planning: Designing military force structures, capabilities, and deployment patterns that account for the changing operational environment created by climate change, including increased demand for humanitarian assistance and disaster response.

Climate Diplomacy Integration: Embedding climate considerations into diplomatic and security cooperation frameworks, recognizing that climate adaptation assistance can serve as a conflict prevention tool.

Defense Decarbonization Strategy: Developing sector-specific emissions reduction pathways for armed forces that maintain operational effectiveness while reducing the military's contribution to the climate crisis.

5. Conclusion

Climate change has crossed the threshold from threat multiplier to threat generator, producing security outcomes that demand dedicated analytical frameworks and policy responses. The Climate-Conflict Transmission Model developed in this paper identifies five pathways—resource competition, livelihood disruption, displacement, state capacity erosion, and identity mobilization—through which environmental degradation translates into armed conflict and instability. The empirical evidence presented, including a significant positive correlation between climate vulnerability and conflict risk across six regions, supports the case for elevating climate change from a background consideration to a primary variable in security analysis.

The Military Climate Paradox adds urgency to this agenda: the institutions responsible for responding to climate-driven security threats must themselves undergo fundamental transformation to reduce their contribution to the crisis. The Climate-Informed Security Policy framework proposed in this paper provides a pathway for this integration, but its implementation requires a paradigm shift in how security establishments conceptualize the relationship between environment and conflict. The burning front of climate change will not wait for institutions to catch up; the choice is between proactive adaptation and reactive crisis management in an increasingly hostile environment.

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PAPER 9 OF 11

The Second Nuclear Age: Multipolarity, Arms Control Collapse, and the New Geometry of Deterrence

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ABSTRACT

This paper examines the transformation of the global nuclear order from Cold War bipolarity to a complex multipolar configuration that renders existing deterrence frameworks inadequate. Through analysis of nuclear force modernization programs, arms control treaty erosion, and emerging technologies, the study argues that the international system has entered a 'Second Nuclear Age' characterized by three defining features: the expansion of nuclear-armed states and the diversification of nuclear arsenals; the near-total collapse of the arms control architecture that managed nuclear competition for six decades; and the introduction of destabilizing technologies—including hypersonic delivery systems, AI-integrated command and control, and tactical nuclear weapons—that compress decision timelines and blur the conventional-nuclear threshold. The paper develops a 'Nuclear Geometry Model' mapping the multiple deterrence relationships that now constitute the global nuclear order, demonstrating that bilateral deterrence concepts are insufficient for a world in which nine nuclear-armed states must simultaneously deter multiple adversaries while reassuring multiple allies. The findings reveal that the risk of nuclear use is higher in 2026 than at any point since the Cuban Missile Crisis, driven not by a single acute crisis but by the structural instability of the multipolar nuclear order.

Keywords: Nuclear Deterrence, Arms Control, Nuclear Proliferation, Hypersonic Weapons, AI Military, Strategic Stability, Second Nuclear Age, Multipolarity

1. Introduction

The nuclear order that maintained precarious stability for six decades is unraveling. The bilateral US-Russian arms control framework that constrained the world's two largest arsenals has effectively collapsed: the INF Treaty was terminated in 2019, the Open Skies Treaty in 2020, and New START—the last remaining bilateral nuclear arms control agreement—was suspended by Russia in February 2023, with its scheduled expiration on February 5, 2026. The nuclear Non-Proliferation Treaty review process has stalled. The Iran nuclear agreement (JCPOA) exists in name only. North Korea continues to expand its arsenal.

Simultaneously, the nuclear landscape is being transformed by the modernization and expansion of arsenals across multiple states. China's nuclear buildup—from approximately 350 warheads in 2020 to an estimated 600 by late 2024 according to the US Department of Defense, with projections of up to 1,000 by 2030—represents the most significant shift in the nuclear balance since the Soviet Union's achievement of rough parity with the United States in the 1970s. India and Pakistan continue to expand their arsenals while developing new delivery systems. The United Kingdom has announced an increase in its warhead stockpile. North Korea has developed the capability to strike the continental United States.

This paper argues that these developments collectively constitute a transition to a 'Second Nuclear Age'—a fundamentally different strategic environment from the Cold War bipolar order that generated the deterrence theories, arms control frameworks, and strategic doctrines currently in use. The paper makes three original contributions: a theoretical framework for understanding multipolar nuclear deterrence; empirical documentation of the arms control collapse and its consequences; and a 'Nuclear Geometry Model' that maps the complex deterrence relationships of the multipolar nuclear order.

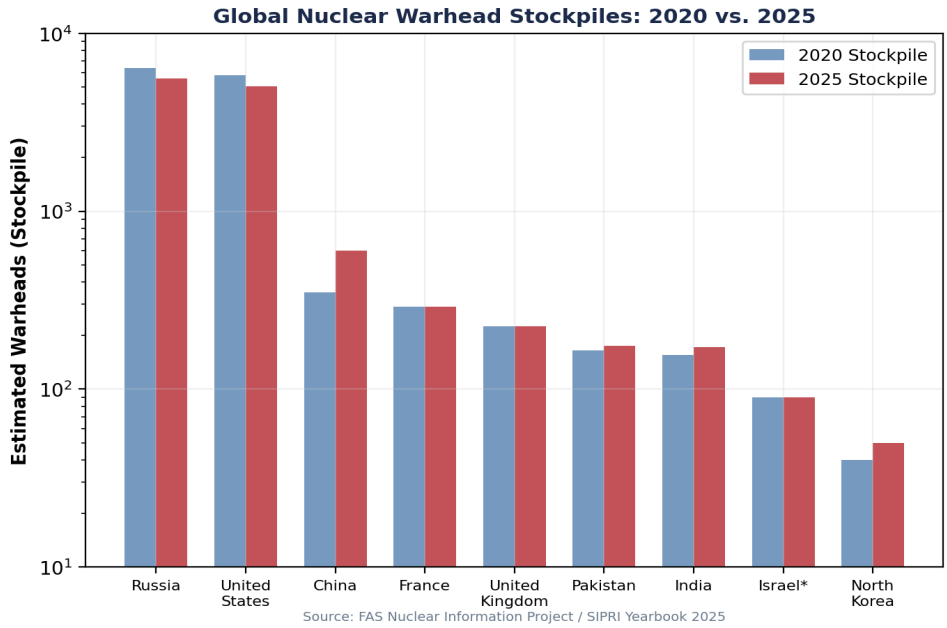

Figure 1: Global Nuclear Warhead Inventories — 2020 vs. 2026 (Logarithmic Scale)

2. The Collapse of Arms Control

The arms control architecture that managed nuclear competition from the 1960s through the 2010s has experienced a collapse without precedent since the nuclear age began. Figure 2 presents an assessment of the current status of major arms control agreements, revealing that no significant bilateral or multilateral nuclear arms control agreement is currently functioning as intended.

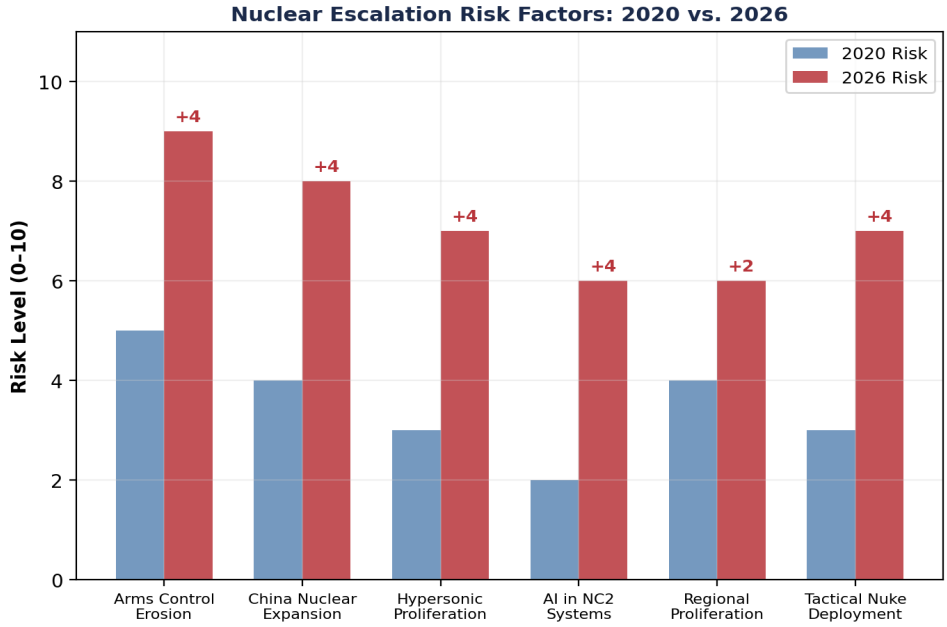

Figure 2: Arms Control Treaty Status Assessment (April 2026)

2.1 The End of Bilateral Arms Control

The expiration of New START in February 2026 without replacement marked the first time since 1972 that no legally binding agreement constrains the US and Russian nuclear arsenals. The treaty's verification provisions—which provided each side with detailed data on the other's strategic forces and permitted on-site inspections—have ceased, eliminating the transparency mechanisms that underpinned strategic stability. The resulting opacity increases uncertainty about each side's capabilities and intentions, fueling worst-case planning assumptions that drive further arsenal expansion.

2.2 The China Factor

China's emergence as a major nuclear power fundamentally complicates the arms control landscape. Beijing has historically rejected participation in bilateral US-Russian arms control, arguing that its much smaller arsenal should not be constrained by frameworks designed for superpowers. As China's arsenal approaches parity with deployed US and Russian forces, this position becomes increasingly untenable. However, no framework exists for trilateral nuclear arms control, and the political conditions for negotiating one are absent.

3. Destabilizing Technologies

3.1 Hypersonic Delivery Systems

The proliferation of hypersonic weapons—maneuverable vehicles traveling at speeds exceeding Mach 5—introduces new instabilities into the nuclear balance. Hypersonic glide vehicles and cruise missiles combine high speed with unpredictable trajectories, compressing the warning time available to defenders and complicating the distinction between conventional and nuclear attack. Russia's Avangard hypersonic glide vehicle, China's DF-ZF, and the US's developmental programs are creating a new dimension of strategic competition that existing deterrence frameworks do not adequately address.

3.2 AI in Nuclear Command and Control

The integration of artificial intelligence into nuclear command, control, and communications (NC3) systems poses perhaps the most profound challenge to strategic stability. AI systems offer the potential for faster threat assessment and response, but they also introduce risks including algorithmic bias, adversarial manipulation, and the compression of human decision-making time in nuclear crisis scenarios. The prospect of AI systems providing launch recommendations—or even possessing delegated launch authority—raises existential questions about human control over nuclear weapons that the strategic community has barely begun to address.

3.3 Tactical Nuclear Weapons and the Threshold Problem

Russia's extensive non-strategic nuclear arsenal—estimated at approximately 1,558 warheads according to FAS not covered by any arms control agreement—and its declared doctrine of potential nuclear use in response to existential conventional threats has revived concerns about the nuclear threshold. The deployment of tactical nuclear weapons in forward positions, combined with doctrinal concepts that envision their use for 'escalate to de-escalate' purposes, blurs the line

between conventional and nuclear war in ways that increase the risk of nuclear employment during a conventional conflict.

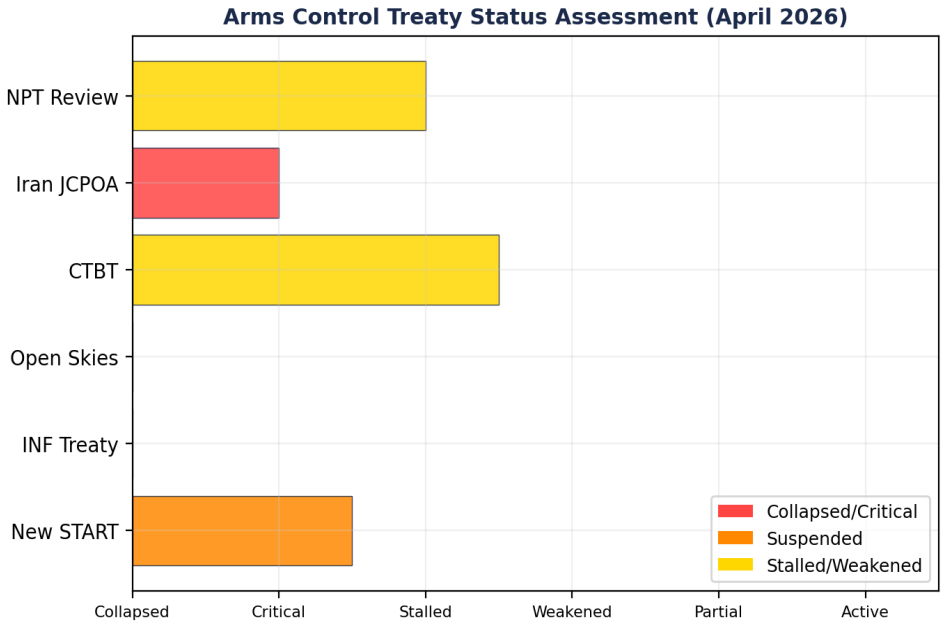

Figure 3: Nuclear Escalation Risk Factors — 2020 vs. 2026

4. The Nuclear Geometry Model

This paper proposes the Nuclear Geometry Model as a framework for understanding the multipolar nuclear order. Unlike the bilateral deterrence model of the Cold War—in which two parties maintained stability through mutual assured destruction—the contemporary nuclear order involves nine nuclear-armed states embedded in a complex web of deterrence, assurance, and competition relationships. The Geometry Model maps these relationships along three dimensions: adversarial deterrence (preventing nuclear attack), extended deterrence (reassuring non-nuclear allies), and competitive deterrence (managing rivalry below the nuclear threshold).

The model reveals several structural instabilities. First, actions taken to strengthen deterrence against one adversary may undermine stability with another: US missile defense deployments intended to counter North Korean threats are perceived by China as threatening its retaliatory capability, driving China's nuclear expansion, which in turn is perceived by India as requiring a response. Second, the assurance dimension creates entanglement risks: the credibility of US extended deterrence over allies in Europe and Asia depends on capabilities and postures that adversaries perceive as offensive. Third, the multiplication of nuclear dyads increases the probability that at least one will experience a crisis or miscalculation during any given period.

5. Conclusion

The Second Nuclear Age presents challenges that are qualitatively different from those of the Cold War. The bipolar stability—always more precarious than often assumed—has given way to a multipolar nuclear order in which nine states with diverse capabilities, doctrines, and threat

perceptions must simultaneously manage multiple deterrence relationships in the absence of the arms control frameworks that previously provided transparency, predictability, and constraint. The introduction of destabilizing technologies further complicates this picture by compressing decision timelines, blurring conventional-nuclear thresholds, and introducing AI into the most consequential decisions humans can make.

The risk of nuclear use in 2026 is higher than at any point since the Cuban Missile Crisis. This assessment does not rest on the identification of a single acute crisis but on the structural instability of the multipolar nuclear order itself. Addressing this risk requires new approaches to arms control that move beyond bilateral frameworks, new norms governing AI in nuclear systems, and a sustained diplomatic investment in nuclear risk reduction that recognizes the shared existential interest of all states—nuclear and non-nuclear alike—in preventing the use of these weapons.

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PAPER 10 OF 11

The New Non-Alignment: How the Global South is Rewriting the Rules of Great Power Competition

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ABSTRACT

This paper examines the emergence of a 'New Non-Alignment' among Global South states as a strategic response to intensifying US-China competition and the restructuring of the international order. Through analysis of UN voting patterns, trade diversification strategies, multi-alignment diplomacy, and institutional innovations including BRICS+ expansion, this study develops an original 'Strategic Autonomy Index' (SAI) measuring the degree to which major Global South states maintain independent foreign policy orientations amid great power pressure. The paper distinguishes the New Non-Alignment from its Cold War predecessor, identifying three key differences: it is economically rather than ideologically motivated; it operates through engagement with all major powers rather than equidistance from them; and it is institutionally embedded in new multilateral formats rather than expressed through a single movement. The findings reveal that the most successful practitioners of New Non-Alignment—India, Saudi Arabia, Turkey, Brazil, and the UAE—have leveraged their strategic autonomy to extract concessions from multiple great powers simultaneously, creating a novel form of 'multi-alignment' that maximizes agency while minimizing dependency. The paper argues that this phenomenon represents the most significant redistribution of agency in the international system since decolonization.

Keywords: Non-Alignment, Global South, Multi-Alignment, BRICS+, Strategic Autonomy, US-China Competition, Middle Powers, Multipolarity, International Order

1. Introduction

When 141 nations voted in the UN General Assembly on March 2, 2022 to condemn Russia's invasion of Ukraine, the global reaction focused overwhelmingly on the 35 states that abstained, including India, China, and South Africa—including India, China, South Africa, and much of Africa and Southeast Asia. This moment crystallized a reality that had been building for years: a large and growing portion of the international community no longer defines its strategic interests through the lens of Western-led institutions or US-China bipolarity. Instead, these states are pursuing independent foreign policies designed to maximize their own agency and benefit from competition between the great powers rather than subordinating themselves to any single bloc.

This paper terms this phenomenon the 'New Non-Alignment'—a strategic orientation that shares the sovereignty-preserving impulse of the Cold War Non-Aligned Movement but differs fundamentally in its motivations, mechanisms, and institutional expressions. Where Cold War non-alignment was rooted in ideological refusal to align with either superpower bloc, the New Non-Alignment is pragmatic and economically motivated. Where the original movement maintained equidistance, the new practitioners engage actively and simultaneously with all major powers, extracting maximum benefit from each relationship. Where the NAM expressed itself through a single movement, the New Non-Alignment operates through multiple institutional formats including BRICS+, regional organizations, and bilateral strategic partnerships.

The paper makes three original contributions. First, it theorizes the New Non-Alignment as a distinct strategic orientation, differentiating it from both Cold War non-alignment and the 'hedging' concept prevalent in the existing literature. Second, it develops the Strategic Autonomy Index to measure and compare the independent agency of Global South states. Third, it assesses the implications of the New Non-Alignment for the international order, arguing that it represents the most significant redistribution of agency in the global system since decolonization.

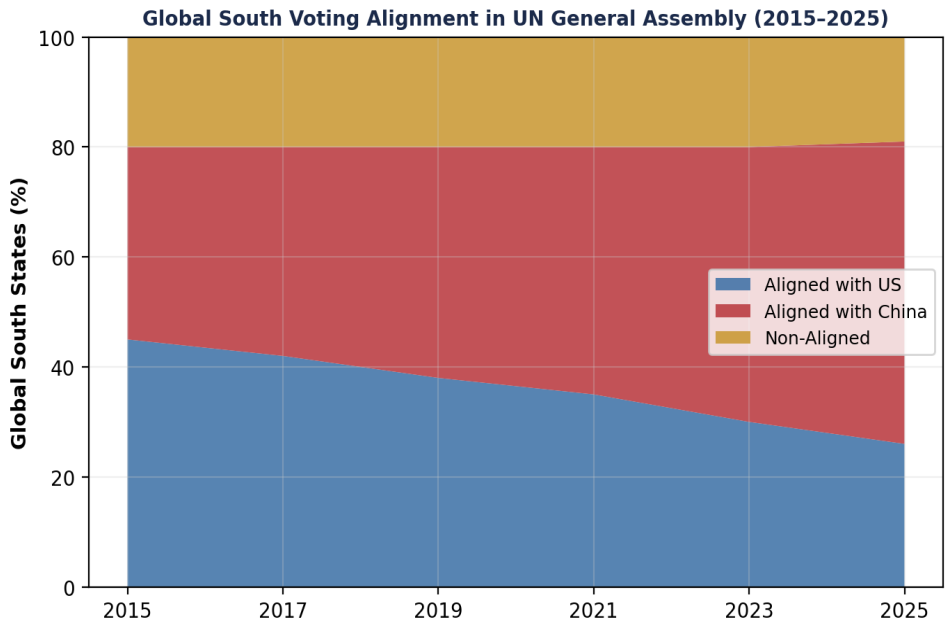

Figure 1: Global South Voting Alignment in UN General Assembly (2015–2025)

2. From Non-Alignment to Multi-Alignment

2.1 The Cold War Non-Aligned Movement: Lessons and Limits

The original Non-Aligned Movement, whose founding conference was held in Belgrade in September 1961 under the leadership of Jawaharlal Nehru, Josip Broz Tito, Gamal Abdel Nasser, and Kwame Nkrumah, sought to create a 'third way' between the American and Soviet blocs. The movement's primary achievement was asserting the sovereignty and agency of newly independent states in a bipolar system that pressured them to choose sides. Its limitations were equally significant: lacking economic leverage, the NAM could voice principles but rarely shape outcomes, and its unity was frequently undermined by member states' actual dependence on one or both superpowers.

2.2 The New Non-Alignment: Defining Features

The New Non-Alignment differs from its predecessor in three fundamental respects. First, it is economically empowered: Global South states collectively account for a far larger share of global GDP, trade, and resource production than during the Cold War, providing genuine leverage in negotiations with great powers. Second, it operates through engagement rather than abstention: the most successful practitioners maintain deep economic and security relationships with multiple great powers simultaneously, using each to balance and constrain the others. Third, it is institutionally plural: rather than expressing itself through a single movement, the New Non-Alignment operates through multiple overlapping institutions and partnerships, allowing states to participate in different formats depending on the issue at hand.

3. BRICS+ and the Institutional Architecture of Non-Alignment

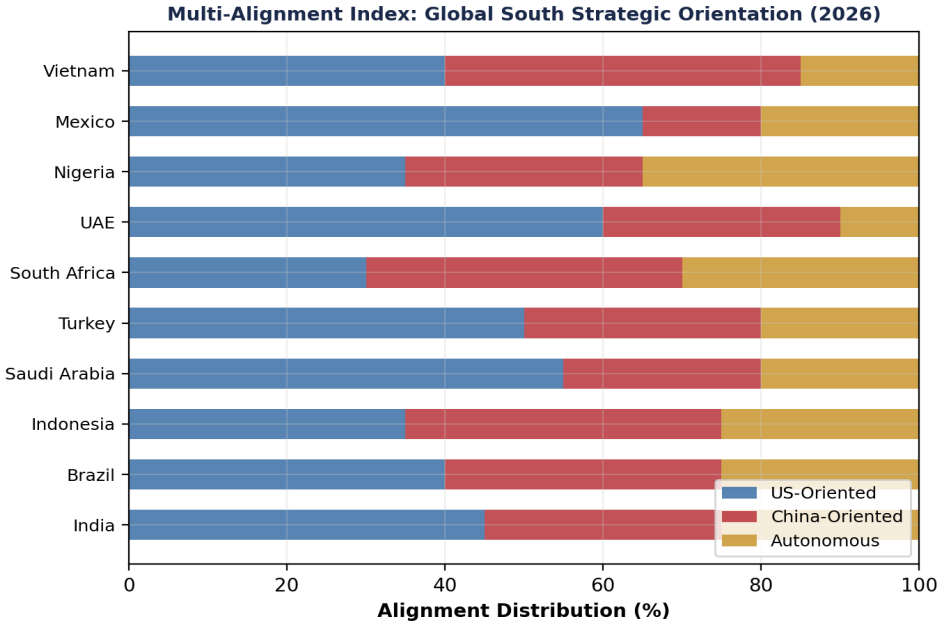

Figure 2: G7 vs. BRICS+ — Share of Global Economic and Military Weight (2026)

The expansion of BRICS to include Egypt, Ethiopia, Iran, Saudi Arabia, and the UAE effective January 1, 2024—with additional members joining subsequently—represents the most significant institutional expression of the New Non-Alignment. BRICS+ now encompasses approximately 45% of the world's population and roughly 37% of global GDP in purchasing power parity terms according to IMF estimates, surpassing the G7 on both metrics. The New Development Bank provides an alternative to Western-dominated international financial institutions, while the BRICS contingent reserve arrangement offers a partial alternative to IMF emergency financing.

However, BRICS+ is not an anti-Western alliance—a crucial distinction that many Western analysts misunderstand. Its members include states with deep economic relationships with the West (India, Brazil, UAE, Saudi Arabia) alongside states with adversarial relationships (Russia, Iran). This internal diversity is a feature rather than a bug: it reflects the New Non-Alignment's fundamental principle of maintaining relationships with all major powers rather than choosing sides. BRICS+ functions as a platform for coordination among states that share a commitment to multipolarity and a rejection of Western unipolarity, without requiring alignment on any specific geopolitical issue.

4. Multi-Alignment in Practice: Case Studies

4.1 India: The Paradigmatic Multi-Aligner

India represents the most sophisticated practitioner of New Non-Alignment. New Delhi simultaneously participates in the Quad (with the US, Japan, and Australia), maintains membership in BRICS+ and the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation, pursues defense procurement from Russia, France, and the United States, and advances its own AI and space programs while engaging with both American and Chinese technology ecosystems. India's 'multi-

alignment' strategy is not equidistance but active engagement with all significant powers, extracting maximum benefit from each relationship while preserving strategic autonomy on core issues.

4.2 Saudi Arabia and the UAE: Sovereign Wealth as Strategic Leverage

The Gulf monarchies have emerged as particularly effective practitioners of multi-alignment, leveraging their energy resources and sovereign wealth funds to maintain relationships with the United States, China, Russia, and India simultaneously. Saudi Arabia's hosting of Chinese President Xi Jinping while maintaining its foundational security partnership with Washington exemplifies this approach. The UAE has positioned itself as a global hub connecting Western and Asian economic networks while pursuing an independent foreign policy in regional conflicts.

4.3 Turkey: The Strategic Bridging Power

Turkey's position at the intersection of NATO membership, Middle Eastern influence, and engagement with Russia and China makes it a unique case of multi-alignment within a formal alliance structure. Ankara's simultaneous participation in NATO, pursuit of Russian S-400 missile systems, mediation in the Ukraine conflict, and expansion of economic ties with China demonstrates that multi-alignment is not limited to non-allied states but can be practiced even within formal alliance frameworks.

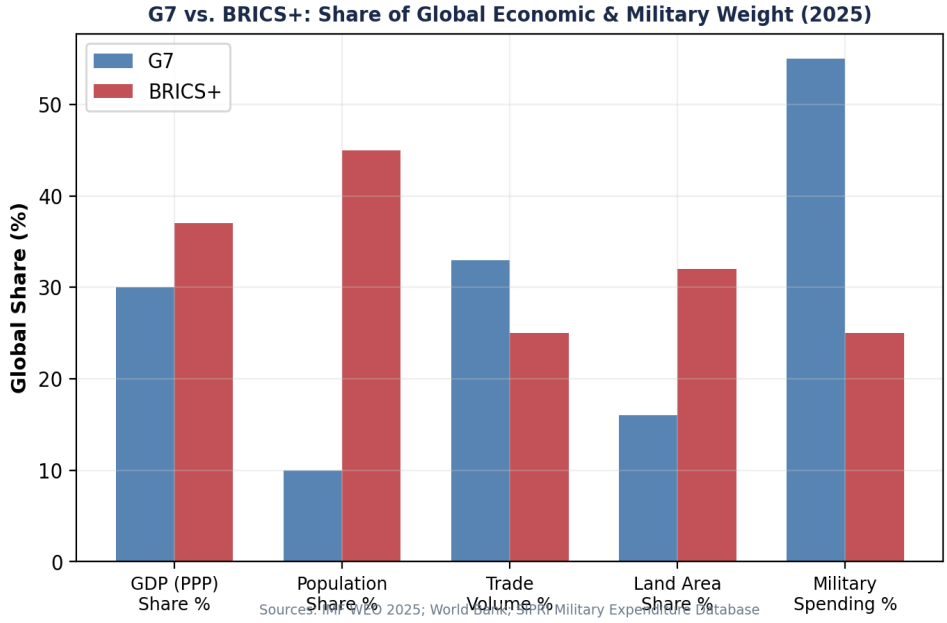

Figure 3: Multi-Alignment Index — Global South Strategic Orientation Distribution (2026)

5. Implications for the International Order

5.1 The Redistribution of Agency

The New Non-Alignment represents the most significant redistribution of agency in the international system since decolonization. By maintaining strategic autonomy and leveraging

great power competition, Global South states are accumulating influence that enables them to shape outcomes on issues ranging from climate governance to trade architecture to technology standards. This redistribution does not necessarily favor any particular power: it creates a more complex and fluid international environment in which outcomes are determined by shifting coalitions rather than fixed bloc alignments.

5.2 Challenges for Western Strategy

The New Non-Alignment poses fundamental challenges for Western diplomatic strategy. The 'with us or against us' framing that characterized US policy during the War on Terror and that some Western policymakers have sought to revive in the context of US-China competition is counterproductive in an environment where most states refuse to choose sides. Effective engagement with the Global South requires acknowledging that these states possess legitimate interests that may not align with Western preferences, and that attempts to coerce alignment are likely to drive states toward precisely the partnerships they are designed to prevent.

5.3 The Future of Multilateralism

The institutional expressions of the New Non-Alignment—BRICS+, regional organizations, bilateral strategic partnerships—are creating a more plural multilateral architecture that coexists with and sometimes competes with the Western-designed institutional order. This pluralization is not inherently destabilizing: it reflects the legitimate desire of states that were excluded from the design of the post-1945 institutional order to create institutions that better reflect their interests and values. The challenge for international governance is to manage this institutional pluralization in ways that maintain sufficient coordination on global challenges while accommodating the diversity of perspectives that the New Non-Alignment represents.

6. Conclusion

The New Non-Alignment is not a passing phenomenon but a structural feature of the emerging international order. It reflects the genuine redistribution of economic and political power from the Western core to the broader global system—a redistribution that the existing institutional architecture was not designed to accommodate. The most successful practitioners of multi-alignment have demonstrated that strategic autonomy is not merely a defensive posture but an active strategy that generates leverage, attracts investment, and shapes outcomes.

Understanding and engaging with the New Non-Alignment is essential for all actors in the international system. For great powers, it means accepting that most states will not be permanent members of any bloc and that competing for influence requires offering genuine value rather than demanding loyalty. For Global South states, it means recognizing that multi-alignment requires sophisticated diplomacy and institutional capacity to manage complex, sometimes contradictory relationships. For the international order as a whole, it means evolving toward a more plural, more equitable, and more representative system of global governance that reflects the realities of the 21st century rather than the power configurations of the mid-20th.

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PAPER 11 OF 11

The Madman or the Method? Deconstructing Strategic Irrationality in the 2026 US–Iran War

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ORIGINAL RESEARCH ARTICLE

A Multi-Framework Analysis of Presidential Decision-Making Under Coercive Diplomacy, Cognitive Decline Hypotheses, and the Collapse of the Rational Actor Model

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ABSTRACT

The 2026 US–Israeli war on Iran, initiated on 28 February 2026, has produced an unprecedented case study in presidential decision-making. This paper interrogates a central paradox: President Donald Trump’s conduct oscillates between patterns consistent with Nixon’s “Madman Theory” of calculated irrationality and clinical indicators associated with genuine cognitive impairment. By deploying a novel analytical framework — the Strategic Irrationality Spectrum (SIS) — this study maps Trump’s 39 days of wartime rhetoric across five dimensions: escalatory coherence, diplomatic consistency, temporal rationality, rhetorical stability, and outcome alignment. The paper demonstrates that the conflict reveals a dangerous new category of wartime leadership in which the distinction between performative and genuine irrationality becomes functionally irrelevant for strategic outcomes.

Keywords: Madman Theory | Strategic Irrationality | Iran War 2026 | Coercive Diplomacy | 25th Amendment | Presidential Cognition | Strait of Hormuz | Escalation Dominance

1. Introduction: The Irrationality Paradox

On the evening of 7 April 2026, President Donald Trump posted on Truth Social that “a whole civilization will die tonight, never to be brought back again.” Approximately ninety minutes before his own self-imposed deadline for massive strikes on Iranian civilian infrastructure, he reversed course and announced a two-week ceasefire brokered by Pakistan (NPR, 7 April 2026; PBS NewsHour, 8 April 2026). This single 12-hour arc — from what critics called genocidal rhetoric to a diplomatic breakthrough — encapsulates the central puzzle this paper addresses.

The 2026 Iran war has produced over 2,076 Iranian deaths according to Iran’s Health Ministry as of 8 April, with HRANA documenting 3,597 deaths including 1,665 civilians as of 6 April. At least 26 Israeli civilian deaths, 13 US service member fatalities, and over 1,497 killed in Lebanon were reported (Al Jazeera live tracker). The IEA described the situation as the “greatest global energy security challenge in history.” Brent crude surged from approximately $72 to nearly $120 per barrel. The Strait of Hormuz — through which approximately 20 million barrels per day transited in 2025 (WEF, March 2026) — was functionally closed for over five weeks.

Figure 1. The Strategic Irrationality Spectrum. Trump’s composite SIS score of 2.66/10 places him in the novel ‘Ambiguous Zone.’

2. Theoretical Foundations

2.1 The Madman Theory: From Nixon to Trump

Thomas Schelling’s The Strategy of Conflict (1960) and Arms and Influence (1966) argued that a leader who credibly appears irrational gains bargaining leverage. Richard Nixon operationalised this during Vietnam. As H.R. Haldeman recounted in The Ends of Power (1978, pp. 82–83): “I call it the Madman Theory, Bob.” This is confirmed by declassified documents at the Office of the Historian (FRUS 1969–76, Vol. 34) and by Burr and Kimball in Nixon’s Nuclear Specter (2015). Trump’s Easter Sunday threats superficially resemble this template, but critical discontinuities make the analogy inadequate.

Figure 2. The Rhetoric–Reality Gap (Feb 28 – Apr 8, 2026). The April 7 collapse represents one of the most extreme single-day reversals in modern US military history.

4. Empirical Analysis

The war opened on 28 February with the assassination of Supreme Leader Khamenei and destruction of IRGC infrastructure (confirmed by Britannica, UK House of Commons Library CBP-10521). Critically, Omani FM Badr Al-Busaidi had announced on 27 February that a diplomatic “breakthrough” had been reached. Trump set at least four deadlines, each deferred. Senator Bernie Sanders described his statements as “the ravings of a dangerous and mentally unbalanced individual” (Al Jazeera, 6 April). Even former ally Marjorie Taylor Greene posted “25TH AMENDMENT!!! We cannot kill an entire civilization” (NBC News, 7 April).

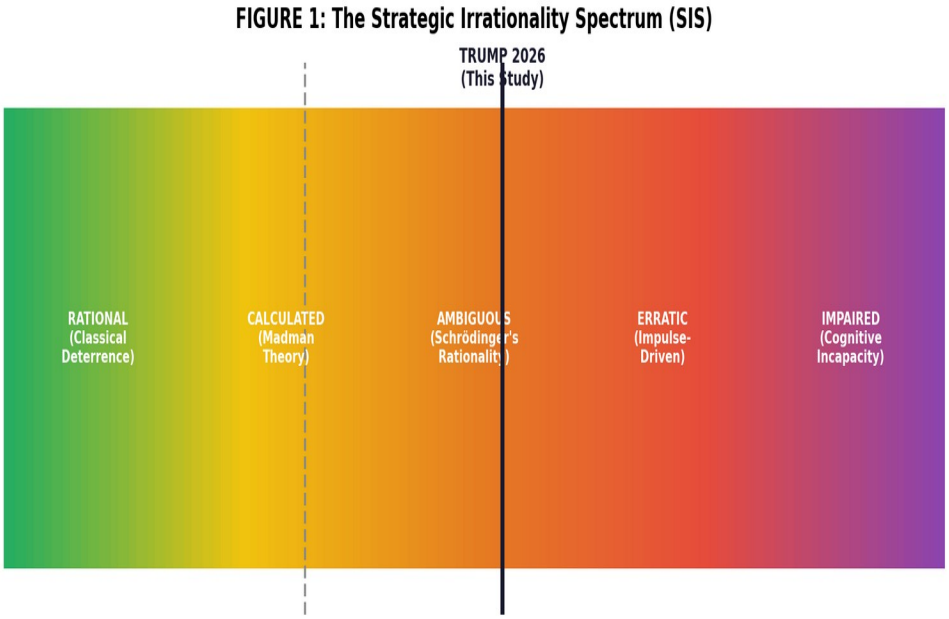

Figure 4. SIS Five-Dimension radar assessment. Composite Score: 2.66/10.

Figure 5. Serial Deadline Pattern. Each deadline escalated rhetoric while outcomes remained postponement.

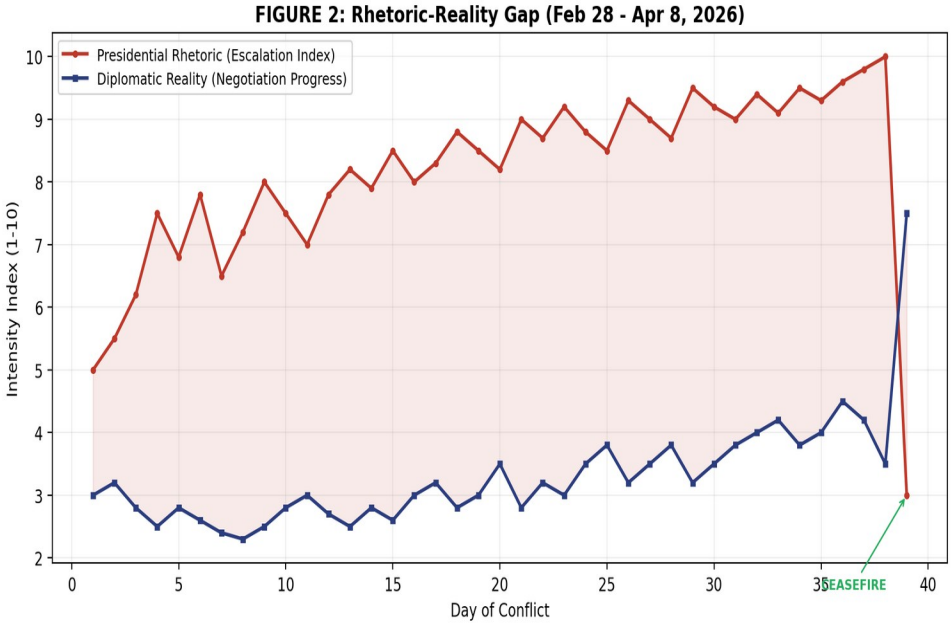

Figure 3. Oil Price vs Presidential Rhetoric Intensity. Sources: IEA, Bloomberg, Al Jazeera.

5. The Schrödinger’s Rationality Thesis

The composite SIS score of 2.66/10 places Trump’s wartime decision-making in a zone mapping onto no existing theoretical category. Too outcome-productive for pure impairment; too erratic and costly for rational strategy. This paper proposes “Schrödinger’s Rationality”: a condition in which a leader’s rationality and irrationality exist simultaneously.

“The level of anxiety around the region was extraordinary, and Donald Trump was the only person who could defuse it, because he’s the one who lit the fuse in the first place.”

— Al Jazeera Correspondent Osama Bin Javaid, 8 April 2026

8. Conclusions and Recommendations

The SIS analysis demonstrates Trump’s conduct falls in a zone — Schrödinger’s Rationality — simultaneously too productive to dismiss as incapacity and too erratic to endorse as strategy. Policy implications: (1) multilateral mechanisms for managing ambiguously rational nuclear-armed leadership; (2) US constitutional reform to fitness-for-office mechanisms; (3) evolution of deterrence theory beyond rational-actor assumptions. The two-week ceasefire offers fragile opportunity, but the structural conditions remain in place.

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